

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Public Service Values, Status and Ethical Dilemmas - Complete Topic Package

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Public Service Values, Status and Ethical Dilemmas

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

1 Public office, Nolan values and essential distinctions

2 Recognising and diagnosing ethical dilemmas

3 Public-service applications: trust, impartiality and compassion

4 Legal floors, public propriety and UPSC close-option traps

5 PYQ demand and a Nolan-based answer thesis

6 Conflict of interest: types, disclosure and proportionate response

7 Coercion, undue influence and unequal workplace power

8 Evidence units: public-private interfaces and institutional safeguards

9 Directive decoding and case-study integration

10 Study links, audited PYQ routes and final synthesis

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / SESSION INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Public Service Values, Status and Ethical Dilemmas - Complete Topic Package	4
CURRENT-AFFAIRS ANCHOR	4
BASIC LEARNING SESSION	4
SESSION 1 - Public office, Nolan values and essential distinctions	4
SESSION 2 - Recognising and diagnosing ethical dilemmas	6
SESSION 3 - Public-service applications: trust, impartiality and compassion	7
SESSION 4 - Legal floors, public propriety and UPSC close-option traps	7
SESSION 5 - PYQ demand and a Nolan-based answer thesis	8
SESSION 6 - Conflict of interest: types, disclosure and proportionate response	8
SESSION 7 - Coercion, undue influence and unequal workplace power	9
SESSION 8 - Evidence units: public-private interfaces and institutional safeguards	10
SESSION 9 - Directive decoding and case-study integration	11
SESSION 10 - Study links, audited PYQ routes and final synthesis	11
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	17
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	41
ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS	48
OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER	51
1. Architecture	51
2. Concepts and distinctions	51
3. Detailed treatment	52
4. Institutional and reform architecture	53
5. Indian applications and boundary cases	53
6. Limitations and trade-offs	54
7. Must-Know Facts for Advanced Prelims	54
8. Advanced Prelims traps	54
9. CURRENT: Current-anchor application	54
10. PYQ-based analytical application	55
11. Mains-ready framework	55

12. Probable questions	55
13. Study links	55
Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)	55
CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES	59
EMBEDDED TWELVE-PANEL ASCII REVISION ATLAS	59
ONE-PAGE CONCEPT GRID	66
CORE REVISION SPINE	67
SOURCE AND ATTRIBUTION DISCIPLINE	68
ANSWER SPINE	68

Public Service Values, Status and Ethical Dilemmas - Complete Topic Package

Subject: Ethics **Section:** Subject-wide Syllabus **Generation:** learner-v2:g1 **Ownership:** GS-IV Ethics topic; recent official-paper questions retain their exact year, paper and source note. **Source policy:** complete Basic owner first; solved practice before optional Advanced depth; consolidated register notes last.

CURRENT-AFFAIRS ANCHOR

DARPG CPGRAMS Monthly Report for Central Ministries/Departments, June 2026

- **FACT:** Fact: The official report is the 50th edition of the CPGRAMS monthly report series.
- **FACT:** Fact: June 2026 was the 48th consecutive month in which Central Secretariat disposal exceeded one lakh grievances.
- **FACT:** Fact: The report records 78,793 pending grievances, with about 68% pending for less than 21 days.
- **FACT:** Fact: It records 83,544 new registrations, 1,96,133 grievances received and 1,99,968 grievances redressed.

ANALYSIS: Inference / administrative link: ANALYSIS: Inference, not an official ethical classification: disposal, pendency, registration and redress indicators illustrate answerability and administrative monitoring. They can support discussion of accountable public service when combined with speaking reasons, review and remedy.

ANALYSIS: Limit: Disposal and pendency data do not establish correctness, fairness, satisfaction, impartiality or absence of misconduct. Do not infer any of those conclusions from the reported metrics.

Official source links:

- <https://darpg.gov.in/static/uploads/2026/07/45cfe50c8de7d2ad837dfabe72bffcdd.pdf>
- <https://darpg.gov.in/documents/reports/cpgrams-monthly-report-centre-ETN0QTMtQWa?pageTitle=CPGRAMS-Monthly-Report-Centre>

Source caution: The Topic 09 Basic and Advanced owners are controlling sources for public-service values, Nolan principles, conflict-of-interest taxonomy, coercion/undue influence and dilemma diagnosis. Topic 09 interfaces with but must not duplicate Topic 10 (laws, rules and conscience), Topic 11 (accountability), Topic 14 (probity), Topic 16 (Codes of Ethics/Conduct) and Topic 22 (complete case-study architecture). The Nolan wording cited by ARC is the 1995 UK formulation, not a claim about the current UK wording. A Code of Conduct should not be called sanctionable solely on ARC 2.2.6 wording. A genuine dilemma is not every unethical act; do not describe GS-IV cases as almost entirely genuine dilemmas. Treat the 2024 Code-of-Ethics statement as a PYQ premise, not a universal current-status finding. Constitutional morality is primarily cross-owned; 2025 Q1(b) must not be claimed as a direct Topic 09 route. Historical ledger labels may be neutral renderings: quote official wording only where verified against the stated local GS-IV PDF.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

SESSION 1 - Public office, Nolan values and essential distinctions

Subject: Ethics | **Tier:** Must-Do (foundation) | **GS Paper:** GS-IV. **Core area:** Status and problems of ethical values in public service; the Nolan principles of public life; the anatomy and resolution of ethical dilemmas. **Grounded in:** 2nd ARC 4th Report *Ethics in Governance* (2007), Ch.2 Ethical Framework (paras 2.2.5-2.2.6, quoting the UK Nolan Committee, 1995); audited GS-IV PYQs (2024-2025 Mains). **FACT:** = source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = analytical inference | **CURRENT:** = current anchor. *Companion:* advanced/09_Public-Service-Values-Status-and-Ethical-Dilemmas.md.

1. Visual foundation

THE SEVEN NOLAN PRINCIPLES OF PUBLIC LIFE (UK Committee on Standards in Public Life, 1995)
cited verbatim by the 2nd ARC (para 2.2.5)

1. Selflessness - decide solely in terms of public interest
2. Integrity - no financial/other obligation that could compromise duty
3. Objectivity - appointments/contracts/benefits on merit alone
4. Accountability - answerable to the public; submit to due scrutiny
5. Openness - be as open as possible; restrict info only when public interest demands
6. Honesty - declare private interests; resolve conflicts to protect public interest
7. Leadership - promote and support these principles by personal example

Core proposition: FACT: ARC 2.2.6 - these principles are "of general applicability in every democracy," and from them flows the need for both a **Code of Ethics** (broad guiding principles) and a **Code of Conduct** (precise standards of acceptable and unacceptable behaviour). Conduct standards become sanctionable where they are incorporated into the applicable legal or service-rule framework; the ARC definition alone does not create a penalty (fully treated in 16).

2. Essential definitions

Concept	Exam-ready meaning
FACT: Ethical dilemma	A situation in which two or more legitimate duties, values or loyalties genuinely conflict, such that honouring one requires compromising another - distinct from a simple temptation to break a known rule.
FACT: Legal violation	A breach of a specific, codified rule/law, independent of whether the underlying situation involved any genuine value conflict.
ANALYSIS: Ethical dilemma vs legal violation	A dilemma may exist even where <i>no law is broken</i> (e.g., choosing between two lawful options with different ethical costs); a legal violation may occur without any real dilemma (e.g., simple theft). GS-IV case studies often contain genuine value conflicts, but some principally test malpractice, corruption or failure to follow a clear duty.
ANALYSIS: Conflict of interest vs corruption	A conflict of interest is a <i>situation</i> , not an act of wrongdoing: a private interest (family, financial, past employment) that could reasonably be thought to compromise official judgment. The ethical failure is the non-disclosure or non-recusal , not the existence of the interest. Corruption requires an actual abuse of office - under the PC Act, an "undue advantage" (see 19). Every conflict of interest left unmanaged is a corruption risk; not every conflict of interest is corruption. Nolan's "honesty" principle is specifically about declaring such interests.
FACT: Code of Ethics (ARC 2.2.6)	Broad guiding principles of good behaviour and governance.
FACT: Code of Conduct (ARC 2.2.6)	A precise, unambiguous list of acceptable and unacceptable behaviour and action. Sanctions depend on the applicable law, service rule or other enforceable framework.
ANALYSIS: Status and role morality	Public status brings asymmetric authority, privileged information and control over public resources; role morality therefore imposes stricter restraint, reason-giving and public-purpose duties than private preference alone.
ANALYSIS: Political neutrality	A permanent civil servant gives frank, evidence-based advice and then implements lawful elected policy without partisan favour; neutrality does not mean ignorance of policy values or indifference to constitutional duties.
ANALYSIS: Responsibility and accountability	Responsibility is the duty to perform and own a decision; accountability adds answerability to appropriate external scrutiny, reasons, remedy and institutional learning.
ANALYSIS: Bounded discretion	Discretion is structured judgment within legal purpose, relevant facts, equal treatment, proportionality, recorded reasons and review - not personal freedom to substitute private morality for public authority.

SESSION 2 - Recognising and diagnosing ethical dilemmas

3. Dilemma-diagnosis anatomy - a pre-answer diagnostic nested inside Basic 22's eight elements

ANALYSIS: This five-step sequence **diagnoses and names a dilemma before writing a full case-study answer** - it is a preparatory diagnostic tool, not itself a 20-mark answer format. In a full Section-B answer it maps onto, and feeds into, Element 1 (facts/naming the dilemma) and Element 5 (ethical evaluation) of the controlling eight-element architecture set out in 22_Case-Study-Method-and-Answer-Architecture.md Sec. 1 (facts, stakeholders, constraints, at least three realistic options, ethical evaluation, decision, implementation/communication, residual-risk mitigation) - this file supplies the Nolan-grounded diagnostic step; 22 remains the controlling answer architecture.

1. **Identify the competing values/duties** - e.g., loyalty to a superior vs duty to the public; compassion for an individual vs impartial rule application; confidentiality vs transparency.

2. **Check for a legal floor** - is one of the options actually illegal, removing it from consideration regardless of its apparent ethical appeal?
3. **Apply a moral-theory lens** (see 08) - duty, consequence, virtue - to each remaining option.
4. **Weigh institutional role and long-term systemic effect**, including the higher restraint created by public status, the elected/permanent-executive boundary, public/private relationship risks and the effect of precedent on similarly placed citizens.
5. **Decide, document and be prepared to be accountable** - Nolan's "accountability" principle requires that the resolution be defensible to public scrutiny, not merely privately justified.

SESSION 3 - Public-service applications: trust, impartiality and compassion

4. Indian applications and examples

- ANALYSIS: An officer asked by a minister to expedite a file for a politically connected applicant faces a genuine dilemma (loyalty to political executive vs impartiality) resolvable by applying identical, transparent processing criteria to all similarly placed applicants (see 04, 11).
- ANALYSIS: A whistleblower employee weighing loyalty to colleagues/organisation against public-interest disclosure of wrongdoing faces the classic dilemma the ARC addresses through whistleblower protection recommendations (see 19).
- ANALYSIS: 2025 GS-IV Q1(b), routed primarily to Topics 13 and 14, is a useful cross-link: its framing of constitutional morality as a product of civic education and rule-of-law adherence shows why dilemma resolution requires disciplined public reason rather than innate virtue alone.

SESSION 4 - Legal floors, public propriety and UPSC close-option traps

5. Must-Know Facts for Prelims

- FACT: The Nolan Committee (UK, formally the Committee on Standards in Public Life, set up in October 1994. issued the seven principles of public life in its First Report of May 1995; the 2nd ARC's 4th Report (2007) reproduces that 1995 wording verbatim at para 2.2.5 as a model for Indian public life. ANALYSIS: The UK's own official wording has since been revised (notably after the 2013 *Standards Matter* review) - quote the ARC's 1995 text when citing the ARC, and check gov.uk if you need the current UK formulation.
- FACT: ARC 2.2.6: a Code of Ethics ≠ a Code of Conduct - the former states broad guiding principles, while the latter states precise acceptable and unacceptable behaviour. Enforcement depends on the legal or service framework adopting the conduct standard.
- ANALYSIS: An ethical dilemma requires a genuine conflict between legitimate values; a mere temptation to break a known rule for personal gain is not, by itself, a dilemma.

6. UPSC traps

- WRONG: Every ethical problem in a case study is really about whether a law was broken. -> Many GS-IV cases contain genuine value conflicts where no law is necessarily broken by every option, while others test a clear violation or abuse that should not be disguised as a dilemma.
- WRONG: The Nolan principles are India-specific. -> They originate from the UK's 1995 Committee on Standards in Public Life and are cited by the ARC as being "of general applicability in every democracy," not as an Indian invention.
- WRONG: "Accountability" and "responsibility" are simply synonyms in the Nolan framework. -> Nolan's

"accountability" specifically means submitting to external scrutiny for decisions taken - see 1.1 for the fuller accountability-vs-responsibility distinction.

SESSION 5 - PYQ demand and a Nolan-based answer thesis

7. PYQ application

- ANALYSIS: 2025 GS-IV Q1(b) is a cross-application on constitutional role morality; its primary routing is to Topics 13 and 14, not direct Topic 09 ownership.
- FACT: 2025 GS-IV Q5(a): Code of Conduct "already in operation" vs Code of Ethics "not yet put in place" - directly tests the ARC 2.2.6 distinction (fully answered in 16).
- FACT: 2025 GS-IV Q7 (Section B case study: DC Vijay) is a textbook multi-duty ethical dilemma (public duty vs family/personal grief) resolvable through the anatomy taught in Section 3 above.

8. Mains angles

- ANALYSIS: Open any dilemma-analysis answer by explicitly stating "this is an ethical dilemma because duties A and B are both legitimate and cannot both be fully honoured" before proposing resolution - naming the dilemma precisely earns early credit.
- ANALYSIS: Use the seven Nolan principles as a checklist to test any proposed resolution: does it remain selfless, objective, accountable, open, honest?

Answer thesis: Ethical dilemmas in public service arise from genuine conflicts between legitimate duties, not merely from temptation to break rules; the Nolan principles provide a checkable standard against which any proposed resolution can be tested for public defensibility.

SESSION 6 - Conflict of interest: types, disclosure and proportionate response

9. Probable questions

- ANALYSIS: **Prelims:** List the seven Nolan principles of public life as cited by the 2nd ARC.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (10 marks):** Distinguish an ethical dilemma from a legal violation, with an example from Indian administration.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (15 marks):** Using the Nolan principles as a checklist, evaluate how a civil servant should resolve a conflict between political-executive instructions and impartial rule application.

10. Conflict of interest - full actual/potential/apparent taxonomy (historical demand)

ANALYSIS: 2018 GS-IV Q3(a) (historical demand, routed here): illustrate conflict of interest as actual vs potential, with examples. Section 2's table already distinguishes conflict of interest from corruption; this section supplies the full, operationally usable three-way taxonomy.

Semantic table split - Type

- **Type:** ANALYSIS: **Actual conflict of interest**
- **Precise meaning:** A private interest and an official duty are *presently* in direct opposition, and a decision is about to be, or has been, taken.
- **Worked Indian/administrative example:** A procurement officer evaluating a tender in which their sibling's firm is a bidder.
- **Operational response:** **Mandatory recusal** from the specific decision; reassignment of the file to another officer; the interest must be formally declared on record.
- **Type:** ANALYSIS: **Potential conflict of interest**

- **Precise meaning:** A private interest *could* come into opposition with official duty in the future, though no specific decision currently requires action.
- **Worked Indian/administrative example:** An officer holds shares in a company operating in a sector they may later be transferred to regulate.
- **Operational response: Proactive disclosure** at the point of posting/appointment; a standing declaration reviewed periodically; no recusal needed yet, but the interest is logged for future screening.
- **Type: ANALYSIS: Apparent (perceived) conflict of interest**
- **Precise meaning:** No actual private interest exists, but a *reasonable observer*, aware of the relevant facts, could suspect that official judgment may be compromised.
- **Worked Indian/administrative example:** An officer processing a routine, rule-bound approval for a childhood friend's application, where the outcome would have been identical for any applicant.
- **Operational response: Transparency, not automatic recusal** - document that the decision followed identical, published criteria; consider voluntary recusal only if public confidence would otherwise be seriously undermined.
- **ANALYSIS: Why the three-way split matters:** treating every *apparent* conflict as if it were *actual*

produces excessive, paralysing recusal that itself damages service delivery; treating every *potential* conflict as irrelevant until it becomes actual removes the chance to manage it proactively - GS-IV rewards naming which of the three types is in play before prescribing a response.

- **ANALYSIS: The Nolan link:** all three types trace back to Nolan's "honesty" principle (declare private interests; resolve conflicts to protect public interest) - see Section 1 - but the *degree* of institutional response (recusal vs disclosure vs transparent documentation) should scale with the type, not apply uniformly.

- **ANALYSIS:** Cross-link: 04_Aptitude-and-Foundational-Values-for-Civil-Service.md, Section 9, treats the

paired historical quotation (Warren Buffett on integrity in hiring) for this same 2018 question.

SESSION 7 - Coercion, undue influence and unequal workplace power

11. Coercion vs undue influence (historical demand)

ANALYSIS: 2023 GS-IV Q2(b) (historical demand, routed here): "differentiate" coercion from undue influence in a work environment.

Aspect	Coercion	Undue influence
ANALYSIS: Mechanism	Compelling action through an explicit or implicit threat of harm (job loss, punitive transfer, physical/reputational harm) - the target's will is overborne by fear.	Exploiting a position of trust, authority or dependency to persuade someone to act against their genuine interest or judgment - the target's will is bent, not broken, often without their full awareness.
ANALYSIS: Consent quality	Consent, if given, is not free - it is extracted under duress.	Apparent consent is given, but it is not fully autonomous - it is shaped by an asymmetric relationship (superior-subordinate, mentor-mentee, examiner-candidate).
ANALYSIS: Workplace example	A supervisor threatening an adverse confidential report unless a subordinate signs off on a flawed inspection certificate.	A senior officer subtly pressuring a junior colleague to "recommend" the senior's preferred vendor by repeatedly emphasising the junior's career depends on the senior's goodwill, without ever issuing a direct threat.
ANALYSIS: Public-office example	A minister's aide threatening to block a routine transfer/posting unless a file is expedited outside due process.	A retiring official steering a post-retirement job offer from a firm they recently regulated, through informal goodwill built over years - no explicit quid pro quo, but the influence is real.
ANALYSIS: Detection difficulty	Easier to detect once reported (a specific threat can usually be identified/evidenced).	Harder to detect - no explicit threat exists; it surfaces only through pattern-of-conduct review (repeated favour-seeking, relationship-based decision skew) or a "reasonable observer" test similar to the apparent-conflict-of-interest test in Section 10.
ANALYSIS: Institutional response	Protection/redress channels (internal complaints committee, vigilance escalation), and treating extracted "consent" as void for the underlying decision.	Cooling-off periods (e.g., post-retirement employment restrictions), rotation of postings to break entrenched dependency relationships, and mandatory recording of reasons for discretionary recommendations.

- ANALYSIS: **Why the distinction is exam-critical:** case studies routinely present *undue influence* (a respected senior "advising" a certain outcome) disguised as ordinary professional courtesy - misreading it as legitimate guidance, rather than naming it as undue influence, is the commonest scoring error; conversely, over-labelling ordinary firm instruction as "coercion" dilutes the precision GS-IV rewards.

SESSION 8 - Evidence units: public-private interfaces and institutional safeguards

12. Selectable named evidence/application units

Pick 1-2 units per answer; each follows claim -> named evidence/example -> significance -> limitation.

1. **Claim:** The dilemma-diagnosis anatomy (Section 3) resolves apparent "no right answer" case studies into a structured decision. **Evidence:** the 2025 GS-IV Q7 DC "Vijay" case (public duty vs personal grief). **Significance:** shows the five-step diagnostic converting an emotionally framed scenario into an analytically tractable one, feeding into 22's Elements 1 and 5. **Limitation:** the diagnostic structures the reasoning; it does not remove the genuine cost of the trade-off actually chosen, nor does it substitute for the full eight-element answer.
2. **Claim:** The actual/potential/apparent conflict-of-interest taxonomy prevents both excessive and insufficient recusal. **Evidence:** the procurement/sibling-firm example (Section 10). **Significance:** gives a proportionate, three-tier institutional response. **Limitation:** borderline cases (is this "apparent" or "actual"?) still require case-by-case

judgment, not a mechanical rule.

3. *Claim*: Undue influence is harder to detect than coercion and requires pattern-based, not incident-based, review. *Evidence*: a post-retirement job offer following years of regulatory goodwill (Section 11). *Significance*: justifies cooling-off periods as a structural, not merely individual-integrity-based, safeguard. *Limitation*: cooling-off periods can be too short to break deeply entrenched relationships, or too long and deter legitimate post-retirement employment.

4. *Claim*: Constitutional morality can require seeking lawful review of an instruction whose application appears inconsistent with constitutional values. *Evidence*: ANALYSIS: 2025 GS-IV Q1(b), cross-routed from Topics 13 and 14, frames constitutional morality as a product of civic education and adherence to the rule of law. *Significance*: shows dilemma-resolution operating above the legality floor, not only within it. *Limitation*: invoking constitutional morality too loosely risks dressing up personal preference as constitutional principle (see 10's advanced-tier caution).

SESSION 9 - Directive decoding and case-study integration

13. Executable directive decoding and answer architecture

Directive word	What is tested	Structural move
Illustrate/Explain	A precise example doing the analytical work	Define the concept -> one worked Indian example -> what it demonstrates
Differentiate	Two concepts kept operationally distinct	Define both -> point-by-point contrast table -> one example each -> the institutional response each requires
Discuss (dilemma)	The dilemma-diagnosis anatomy applied to a scenario, nested in 22's architecture	Name the dilemma -> competing duties -> legality check -> theory lens (08) -> Nolan-checklist verdict -> (if 20 marks) carry into 22's full eight elements

10-mark architecture (~150 words): name the concept (dilemma/COI type/coercion vs undue influence) precisely -> one worked Indian/administrative example (Section 12) -> the specific institutional response it requires -> one-line conclusion.

20-mark case-study architecture: This file does **not** carry its own abbreviated case-study format. Every GS-IV Section-B (20-mark) case study must be built on the full, controlling eight-element architecture in `22_Case-Study-Method-and-Answer-Architecture.md`. Sec. 1 - facts, stakeholders, constraints, **at least three** realistic options (never cap at two, and steelman the single strongest objection to the chosen decision, 22 Sec. 6), named ethical evaluation (the six-check framework), decision, implementation/communication, and residual-risk mitigation. This file's dilemma-diagnosis anatomy (Section 3), Nolan checklist (Section 1) and conflict-of-interest/coercion-undue-influence taxonomies (Sections 10-11) feed Elements 1 and 5 of that architecture - they are not themselves a rival 20-mark format.

Counterpoint and reasoned verdict (template): "[Named type/response] is the proportionate answer here because [reason]; treating it as [the more/less severe alternative type] would risk [named failure mode]."

SESSION 10 - Study links, audited PYQ routes and final synthesis

14. Study links

- FACT: Advanced companion:
`advanced/09_Public-Service-Values-Status-and-Ethical-Dilemmas.md`.
- FACT: `16_Codes-of-Ethics-and-Codes-of-Conduct.md` - full Code of Ethics/Conduct treatment.
- FACT: `11_Accountability-and-Ethical-Governance.md` - the accountability principle in depth.
- FACT: `22_Case-Study-Method-and-Answer-Architecture.md` - the controlling eight-element architecture into which this file's dilemma-diagnosis anatomy (Section 3) nests.

- FACT: 04_Aptitude-and-Foundational-Values-for-Civil-Service.md - the paired Warren Buffett quotation.

Recent PYQ Integration (2024-2025)

Status: 2024-2025 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS3-GS4-2024-2025.md.

- **Years represented:** 2024, 2025
- **Paper(s):** GS-IV
- **Routed question demands:** 7

Semantic table split - Year

- **Year:** 2024
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 5
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) code of conduct and code of ethics in public administration; (b) BNS rooted in Indian culture
- **Directive / format:** Section A theory · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2024
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: Rohit and a multi-pronged strategy in LWE-affected States
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2024
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: District Collector amid acute water scarcity
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2025
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 5
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) devotion to duty and personal fulfilment; (b) civil servant as enabler and facilitator
- **Directive / format:** Section A theory · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2025
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7

- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: Vijay, Deputy Commissioner of a remote district in a hilly northern State
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2025
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: Subash - ethical issues and options
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2025
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: Ashok - ethical and legal dilemmas
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.

What this owner must now support

- (a) code of conduct and code of ethics in public administration; (b) BNS rooted in Indian culture
- Case study: Rohit and a multi-pronged strategy in LWE-affected States
- Case study: District Collector amid acute water scarcity
- (a) devotion to duty and personal fulfilment; (b) civil servant as enabler and facilitator
- Case study: Vijay, Deputy Commissioner of a remote district in a hilly northern State
- Case study: Subash - ethical issues and options
- Case study: Ashok - ethical and legal dilemmas

This block integrates the 2024-2025 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 block and does not convert an unkeyed/answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS3-GS4-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023
- **Paper(s):** GS-IV
- **Routed question demands:** 15

Semantic table split - Year

- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 2
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) meaning of public interest and principles for civil servants; (b) RTI redefining the concept of accountability
- **Directive / format:** Explain/Discuss · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic

- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 3
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) conflict of interest - actual vs potential with examples; (b) Warren Buffett quote on integrity intelligence and energy for hiring
- **Directive / format:** Illustrate/Explain · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 5
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) government dam construction in forest valley inhabited by ethnic communities - rational policy for unforeseen contingencies; (b) process of resolving ethical dilemmas in public administration
- **Directive / format:** Suggest/Explain · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Rakesh (district officer) - elderly couple applies for senior citizen healthcare scheme; surgeon willing to operate free but couple cannot afford incidental costs; how should he respond
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** SP appointed in prohibition state notorious for illicit liquor distillation causing deaths; what new approach to bring problem under control
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 1
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) basic principles of public life with examples; (b) meaning of public servant and expected role
- **Directive / format:** Discuss · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic

- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Woman SP appointed in frontier narcotics district - money laundering poppy farming arms smuggling education collapse; identify dimensions and suggest measures to restore normalcy
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** DC of tribal Rampura district: minor girls trafficked to cotton farms as child labour by contractors; identify ethical issues; steps to ameliorate conditions and economic scenario
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** migrant workers during COVID lockdown: ethical issues in crisis; meaning of ethical care and ethical giving; civil society role in mitigating migrant suffering
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 2
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) digital technology as reliable input for rational decision making - critically evaluate; (b) innovativeness and creativity in resolving ethical dilemmas
- **Directive / format:** Critically evaluate / Discuss · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Vice Principal faces management pressure to suppress exam cheating involving students of influential local politician and businessman - (a) ethical issues; (b) options and best course
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method

- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** COVID-19 hospital administrator: criteria and justification for deploying clinical and non-clinical staff in infectious crisis; whether justification differs for a private hospital
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2022
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 1
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) wisdom in administration and travesty of justice in service delivery; (b) empathy and compassion as vital attributes for civil servants
- **Directive / format:** Critically evaluate (a); Explain (b) · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 2
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) corruption as failure of core values and measures to uplift society; (b) coercion vs undue influence in work environment
- **Directive / format:** Discuss (a); Differentiate (b) · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on District Magistrate (AIIMS physician) facing blood-transfusion dilemma during a landslide relief operation
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.

What this owner must now support

- (a) meaning of public interest and principles for civil servants; (b) RTI redefining the concept of accountability
- (a) conflict of interest - actual vs potential with examples; (b) Warren Buffett quote on integrity intelligence and energy for hiring
- (a) government dam construction in forest valley inhabited by ethnic communities - rational policy for unforeseen contingencies; (b) process of resolving ethical dilemmas in public administration
- Rakesh (district officer) - elderly couple applies for senior citizen healthcare scheme; surgeon willing to operate free but couple cannot afford incidental costs; how should he respond

- SP appointed in prohibition state notorious for illicit liquor distillation causing deaths; what new approach to bring problem under control
- (a) basic principles of public life with examples; (b) meaning of public servant and expected role
- Woman SP appointed in frontier narcotics district - money laundering poppy farming arms smuggling education collapse; identify dimensions and suggest measures to restore normalcy
- DC of tribal Rampura district: minor girls trafficked to cotton farms as child labour by contractors; identify ethical issues; steps to ameliorate conditions and economic scenario
- migrant workers during COVID lockdown: ethical issues in crisis; meaning of ethical care and ethical giving; civil society role in mitigating migrant suffering
- (a) digital technology as reliable input for rational decision making - critically evaluate; (b) innovativeness and creativity in resolving ethical dilemmas
- Vice Principal faces management pressure to suppress exam cheating involving students of influential local politician and businessman - (a) ethical issues; (b) options and best course
- COVID-19 hospital administrator: criteria and justification for deploying clinical and non-clinical staff in infectious crisis; whether justification differs for a private hospital
- (a) wisdom in administration and travesty of justice in service delivery; (b) empathy and compassion as vital attributes for civil servants
- (a) corruption as failure of core values and measures to uplift society; (b) coercion vs undue influence in work environment
- Case on District Magistrate (AIIMS physician) facing blood-transfusion dilemma during a landslide relief operation

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

A district officer uses an official guest house for a family celebration because it is vacant. Which public-service proposition makes the convenience ethically relevant? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public office confers entrusted authority, information and discretion for public purpose; status therefore increases rather than relaxes the duty of restraint, reason-giving and conduct that can retain citizens' confidence.
- B. Role morality gives an official special duties of fidelity, competence and impartial implementation, but it cannot licence discrimination, concealment or personal loyalty where these defeat constitutional values, lawful authority or public interest.
- C. Public interest concerns constitutionally permissible, evidence-based welfare of the community, including affected minorities and future citizens; it is not identical to electoral popularity, a minister's preference or the loudest group's immediate demand.
- D. Because public authority depends on confidence, officials should avoid impropriety and its reasonable appearance; this is not a demand for private perfection but a duty to manage relationships and conduct that could credibly compromise official judgment.

Answer: A

Explanation: Public office is a public trust is the controlling principle. Public office confers entrusted authority, information and discretion for public purpose; status therefore increases rather than relaxes the duty of restraint, reason-giving and conduct that can retain citizens' confidence. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 2

A regulator says senior rank permits informal favours that junior staff cannot give. Which conception of office rejects this reasoning? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public interest concerns constitutionally permissible, evidence-based welfare of the community, including affected minorities and future citizens; it is not identical to electoral popularity, a minister's preference or the loudest group's immediate demand.
- B. Public office confers entrusted authority, information and discretion for public purpose; status therefore increases rather than relaxes the duty of restraint, reason-giving and conduct that can retain citizens' confidence.
- C. Because public authority depends on confidence, officials should avoid impropriety and its reasonable appearance; this is not a demand for private perfection but a duty to manage relationships and conduct that could credibly compromise official judgment.
- D. Role morality gives an official special duties of fidelity, competence and impartial implementation, but it cannot licence discrimination, concealment or personal loyalty where these defeat constitutional values, lawful authority or public interest.

Answer: B

Explanation: Public office is a public trust is the controlling principle. Public office confers entrusted authority, information and discretion for public purpose; status therefore increases rather than relaxes the duty of restraint, reason-giving and conduct that can retain citizens' confidence. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 3

A licensing officer says loyalty to her department requires concealing an unlawful selection practice. What qualification to role loyalty is decisive? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public office confers entrusted authority, information and discretion for public purpose; status therefore increases rather than relaxes the duty of restraint, reason-giving and conduct that can retain citizens' confidence.
- B. Public interest concerns constitutionally permissible, evidence-based welfare of the community, including affected minorities and future citizens; it is not identical to electoral popularity, a minister's preference or the loudest group's immediate demand.
- C. Role morality gives an official special duties of fidelity, competence and impartial implementation, but it cannot licence discrimination, concealment or personal loyalty where these defeat constitutional values, lawful authority or public interest.
- D. Because public authority depends on confidence, officials should avoid impropriety and its reasonable appearance; this is not a demand for private perfection but a duty to manage relationships and conduct that could credibly compromise official judgment.

Answer: C

Explanation: Role morality is bounded by constitutional public purpose is the controlling principle. Role morality gives an official special duties of fidelity, competence and impartial implementation, but it cannot licence discrimination, concealment or personal loyalty where these defeat constitutional values, lawful authority or public interest. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 4

A collector implements an unpopular but lawful welfare eligibility rule equally after recording reasons. Which feature makes this role-based conduct defensible? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public interest concerns constitutionally permissible, evidence-based welfare of the community, including affected minorities and future citizens; it is not identical to electoral popularity, a minister's preference or the loudest group's immediate demand.
- B. Because public authority depends on confidence, officials should avoid impropriety and its reasonable appearance; this is not a demand for private perfection but a duty to manage relationships and conduct that could credibly compromise official judgment.
- C. Public office confers entrusted authority, information and discretion for public purpose; status therefore increases rather than relaxes the duty of restraint, reason-giving and conduct that can retain citizens' confidence.
- D. Role morality gives an official special duties of fidelity, competence and impartial implementation, but it cannot licence discrimination, concealment or personal loyalty where these defeat constitutional values, lawful authority or public interest.

Answer: D

Explanation: Role morality is bounded by constitutional public purpose is the controlling principle. Role morality gives an official special duties of fidelity, competence and impartial implementation, but it cannot licence discrimination, concealment or personal loyalty where these defeat constitutional values, lawful authority or public interest. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 5

Residents demand that a night shelter be moved away before elections despite no alternative site. Which distinction should guide the municipal commissioner? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public interest concerns constitutionally permissible, evidence-based welfare of the community, including affected minorities and future citizens; it is not identical to electoral popularity, a minister's preference or the loudest group's immediate demand.
- B. Public office confers entrusted authority, information and discretion for public purpose; status therefore increases rather than relaxes the duty of restraint, reason-giving and conduct that can retain citizens' confidence.
- C. Role morality gives an official special duties of fidelity, competence and impartial implementation, but it cannot licence discrimination, concealment or personal loyalty where these defeat constitutional values, lawful authority or public interest.
- D. Because public authority depends on confidence, officials should avoid impropriety and its reasonable appearance; this is not a demand for private perfection but a duty to manage relationships and conduct that could credibly compromise official judgment.

Answer: A

Explanation: Public interest is not majoritarian preference is the controlling principle. Public interest concerns constitutionally permissible, evidence-based welfare of the community, including affected minorities and future citizens; it is not identical to electoral popularity, a minister's preference or the loudest group's immediate demand. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 6

A minister seeks a road diversion that benefits supporters but displaces a poorer hamlet without hearing. Which public-interest test is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Role morality gives an official special duties of fidelity, competence and impartial implementation, but it cannot licence discrimination, concealment or personal loyalty where these defeat constitutional values, lawful authority or public interest.
- B. Public interest concerns constitutionally permissible, evidence-based welfare of the community, including affected minorities and future citizens; it is not identical to electoral popularity, a minister's preference or the loudest group's immediate demand.
- C. Because public authority depends on confidence, officials should avoid impropriety and its reasonable appearance; this is not a demand for private perfection but a duty to manage relationships and conduct that could credibly compromise official judgment.
- D. Public office confers entrusted authority, information and discretion for public purpose; status therefore increases rather than relaxes the duty of restraint, reason-giving and conduct that can retain citizens' confidence.

Answer: B

Explanation: Public interest is not majoritarian preference is the controlling principle. Public interest concerns constitutionally permissible, evidence-based welfare of the community, including affected minorities and future citizens; it is not identical to electoral popularity, a minister's preference or the loudest group's immediate demand. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 7

An officer attends a bidder's lavish family function during tender evaluation but claims no favour was requested. Which ethical risk remains? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public office confers entrusted authority, information and discretion for public purpose; status therefore increases rather than relaxes the duty of restraint, reason-giving and conduct that can retain citizens' confidence.
- B. Role morality gives an official special duties of fidelity, competence and impartial implementation, but it cannot licence discrimination, concealment or personal loyalty where these defeat constitutional values, lawful authority or public interest.
- C. Because public authority depends on confidence, officials should avoid impropriety and its reasonable appearance; this is not a demand for private perfection but a duty to manage relationships and conduct that could credibly compromise official judgment.
- D. Public interest concerns constitutionally permissible, evidence-based welfare of the community, including affected minorities and future citizens; it is not identical to electoral popularity, a minister's preference or the loudest group's immediate demand.

Answer: C

Explanation: Status creates an appearance obligation is the controlling principle. Because public authority depends on confidence, officials should avoid impropriety and its reasonable appearance; this is not a demand for private perfection but a duty to manage relationships and conduct that could credibly compromise official judgment. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 8

A public hospital superintendent publicly discloses a relative's connection before a procurement decision. Which confidence-preserving duty is being served? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Role morality gives an official special duties of fidelity, competence and impartial implementation, but it cannot licence discrimination, concealment or personal loyalty where these defeat constitutional values, lawful authority or public interest.
- B. Public interest concerns constitutionally permissible, evidence-based welfare of the community, including affected minorities and future citizens; it is not identical to electoral popularity, a minister's preference or the loudest group's immediate demand.
- C. Public office confers entrusted authority, information and discretion for public purpose; status therefore increases rather than relaxes the duty of restraint, reason-giving and conduct that can retain citizens' confidence.
- D. Because public authority depends on confidence, officials should avoid impropriety and its reasonable appearance; this is not a demand for private perfection but a duty to manage relationships and conduct that could credibly compromise official judgment.

Answer: D

Explanation: Status creates an appearance obligation is the controlling principle. Because public authority depends on confidence, officials should avoid impropriety and its reasonable appearance; this is not a demand for private perfection but a duty to manage relationships and conduct that could credibly compromise official judgment. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 9

A mining inspector accepts repeated hospitality from a company he may inspect next month. Which Nolan principle identifies the prior risk? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nolan integrity requires public office holders not to place themselves under financial or other obligations that might influence official duty; risk of compromised judgment matters before proof of actual bias or corrupt payment.
- B. Nolan objectivity requires appointments, contracts and benefits to be decided on merit and stated criteria; it is a procedural guard against favouritism, not a claim that public policy can be wholly value-neutral.
- C. Impartiality applies relevant criteria equally among persons; political neutrality requires non-partisan advice and implementation under the elected government. Neither requires indifference to constitutional rights, evidence or unlawful directions.
- D. Accountability requires an office holder to explain and justify decisions to appropriate external scrutiny and accept consequences or correction; it exceeds private sincerity and differs from merely having responsibility to perform an assigned task.

Answer: A

Explanation: Integrity excludes compromising obligations is the controlling principle. Nolan integrity requires public office holders not to place themselves under financial or other obligations that might influence official duty; risk of compromised judgment matters before proof of actual bias or corrupt payment. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 10

A procurement member declares an investment and withdraws before bids are opened. Which value is operationalised even without proof of bias? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Impartiality applies relevant criteria equally among persons; political neutrality requires non-partisan advice and implementation under the elected government. Neither requires indifference to constitutional rights, evidence or unlawful directions.
- B. Nolan integrity requires public office holders not to place themselves under financial or other obligations that might influence official duty; risk of compromised judgment matters before proof of actual bias or corrupt payment.
- C. Accountability requires an office holder to explain and justify decisions to appropriate external scrutiny and accept consequences or correction; it exceeds private sincerity and differs from merely having responsibility to perform an assigned task.
- D. Nolan objectivity requires appointments, contracts and benefits to be decided on merit and stated criteria; it is a procedural guard against favouritism, not a claim that public policy can be wholly value-neutral.

Answer: B

Explanation: Integrity excludes compromising obligations is the controlling principle. Nolan integrity requires public office holders not to place themselves under financial or other obligations that might influence official duty; risk of compromised judgment matters before proof of actual bias or corrupt payment. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 11

A scholarship committee publishes scoring criteria and anonymises applications. Which Nolan principle is most directly strengthened? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nolan integrity requires public office holders not to place themselves under financial or other obligations that might influence official duty; risk of compromised judgment matters before proof of actual bias or corrupt payment.
- B. Impartiality applies relevant criteria equally among persons; political neutrality requires non-partisan advice and implementation under the elected government. Neither requires indifference to constitutional rights, evidence or unlawful directions.
- C. Nolan objectivity requires appointments, contracts and benefits to be decided on merit and stated criteria; it is a procedural guard against favouritism, not a claim that public policy can be wholly value-neutral.
- D. Accountability requires an office holder to explain and justify decisions to appropriate external scrutiny and accept consequences or correction; it exceeds private sincerity and differs from merely having responsibility to perform an assigned task.

Answer: C

Explanation: Objectivity is merit-based official procedure is the controlling principle. Nolan objectivity requires appointments, contracts and benefits to be decided on merit and stated criteria; it is a procedural guard against favouritism, not a claim that public policy can be wholly value-neutral. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 12

An officer says a compassionate policy choice proves objectivity because it is humane. Which distinction corrects the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Impartiality applies relevant criteria equally among persons; political neutrality requires non-partisan advice and implementation under the elected government. Neither requires indifference to constitutional rights, evidence or unlawful directions.
- B. Accountability requires an office holder to explain and justify decisions to appropriate external scrutiny and accept consequences or correction; it exceeds private sincerity and differs from merely having responsibility to perform an assigned task.
- C. Nolan integrity requires public office holders not to place themselves under financial or other obligations that might influence official duty; risk of compromised judgment matters before proof of actual bias or corrupt payment.
- D. Nolan objectivity requires appointments, contracts and benefits to be decided on merit and stated criteria; it is a procedural guard against favouritism, not a claim that public policy can be wholly value-neutral.

Answer: D

Explanation: Objectivity is merit-based official procedure is the controlling principle. Nolan objectivity requires appointments, contracts and benefits to be decided on merit and stated criteria; it is a procedural guard against favouritism, not a claim that public policy can be wholly value-neutral. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 13

A district officer applies the same relief criteria to supporters and opponents of the ruling party. What value is directly displayed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Impartiality applies relevant criteria equally among persons; political neutrality requires non-partisan advice and implementation under the elected government. Neither requires indifference to constitutional rights, evidence or unlawful directions.
- B. Nolan integrity requires public office holders not to place themselves under financial or other obligations that might influence official duty; risk of compromised judgment matters before proof of actual bias or corrupt payment.
- C. Nolan objectivity requires appointments, contracts and benefits to be decided on merit and stated criteria; it is a procedural guard against favouritism, not a claim that public policy can be wholly value-neutral.
- D. Accountability requires an office holder to explain and justify decisions to appropriate external scrutiny and accept consequences or correction; it exceeds private sincerity and differs from merely having responsibility to perform an assigned task.

Answer: A

Explanation: Impartiality and political neutrality differ is the controlling principle. Impartiality applies relevant criteria equally among persons; political neutrality requires non-partisan advice and implementation under the elected government. Neither requires indifference to constitutional rights, evidence or unlawful directions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 14

A secretary gives frank written advice against an illegal proposal, then implements a lawful revised decision without partisan comment. What role ethic is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nolan objectivity requires appointments, contracts and benefits to be decided on merit and stated criteria; it is a procedural guard against favouritism, not a claim that public policy can be wholly value-neutral.
- B. Impartiality applies relevant criteria equally among persons; political neutrality requires non-partisan advice and implementation under the elected government. Neither requires indifference to constitutional rights, evidence or unlawful directions.
- C. Accountability requires an office holder to explain and justify decisions to appropriate external scrutiny and accept consequences or correction; it exceeds private sincerity and differs from merely having responsibility to perform an assigned task.
- D. Nolan integrity requires public office holders not to place themselves under financial or other obligations that might influence official duty; risk of compromised judgment matters before proof of actual bias or corrupt payment.

Answer: B

Explanation: Impartiality and political neutrality differ is the controlling principle. Impartiality applies relevant criteria equally among persons; political neutrality requires non-partisan advice and implementation under the elected government. Neither requires indifference to constitutional rights, evidence or unlawful directions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 15

A programme director meets targets but refuses to disclose beneficiary-selection reasons to an audit. Which public value is deficient? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nolan integrity requires public office holders not to place themselves under financial or other obligations that might influence official duty; risk of compromised judgment matters before proof of actual bias or corrupt payment.
- B. Nolan objectivity requires appointments, contracts and benefits to be decided on merit and stated criteria; it is a procedural guard against favouritism, not a claim that public policy can be wholly value-neutral.
- C. Accountability requires an office holder to explain and justify decisions to appropriate external scrutiny and accept consequences or correction; it exceeds private sincerity and differs from merely having responsibility to perform an assigned task.
- D. Impartiality applies relevant criteria equally among persons; political neutrality requires non-partisan advice and implementation under the elected government. Neither requires indifference to constitutional rights, evidence or unlawful directions.

Answer: C

Explanation: Accountability is answerability to scrutiny is the controlling principle. Accountability requires an office holder to explain and justify decisions to appropriate external scrutiny and accept consequences or correction; it exceeds private sincerity and differs from merely having responsibility to perform an assigned task. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 16

A block officer records alternatives, publishes reasons and corrects an exclusion after appeal. Which form of accountability is visible? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nolan objectivity requires appointments, contracts and benefits to be decided on merit and stated criteria; it is a procedural guard against favouritism, not a claim that public policy can be wholly value-neutral.
- B. Impartiality applies relevant criteria equally among persons; political neutrality requires non-partisan advice and implementation under the elected government. Neither requires indifference to constitutional rights, evidence or unlawful directions.
- C. Nolan integrity requires public office holders not to place themselves under financial or other obligations that might influence official duty; risk of compromised judgment matters before proof of actual bias or corrupt payment.
- D. Accountability requires an office holder to explain and justify decisions to appropriate external scrutiny and accept consequences or correction; it exceeds private sincerity and differs from merely having responsibility to perform an assigned task.

Answer: D

Explanation: Accountability is answerability to scrutiny is the controlling principle. Accountability requires an office holder to explain and justify decisions to appropriate external scrutiny and accept consequences or correction; it exceeds private sincerity and differs from merely having responsibility to perform an assigned task. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 17

During a cloudburst, a deputy commissioner must choose between leading fragile rescue operations and attending a parent's last rites. Why is this a genuine dilemma? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An ethical dilemma arises when two legitimate duties, values or loyalties cannot both be fully honoured; it differs from a simple temptation to obtain gain by breaking a known rule or disguising favouritism as compassion.
- B. A legal prohibition removes an option from ordinary ethical choice, but technical legality does not automatically establish morality or propriety; officials must also test public purpose, equality, constitutional values, reasons and foreseeable institutional effects.
- C. Dilemma resolution begins by identifying affected citizens, weaker groups, colleagues, institutions and future interests; mapping them exposes hidden burdens before an official chooses among lawful alternatives or invokes a public-good slogan.
- D. After excluding unlawful options, an official should compare realistic alternatives through duties, consequences and virtues, select a proportionate option, record reasons, communicate it fairly and mitigate residual harm under independent or administrative review.

Answer: A

Explanation: A genuine dilemma conflicts legitimate duties is the controlling principle. An ethical dilemma arises when two legitimate duties, values or loyalties cannot both be fully honoured; it differs from a simple temptation to obtain gain by breaking a known rule or disguising favouritism as compassion. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 18

An officer calls accepting a contractor's gift a dilemma between friendship and duty. What diagnosis should precede balancing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Dilemma resolution begins by identifying affected citizens, weaker groups, colleagues, institutions and future interests; mapping them exposes hidden burdens before an official chooses among lawful alternatives or invokes a public-good slogan.
- B. An ethical dilemma arises when two legitimate duties, values or loyalties cannot both be fully honoured; it differs from a simple temptation to obtain gain by breaking a known rule or disguising favouritism as compassion.
- C. After excluding unlawful options, an official should compare realistic alternatives through duties, consequences and virtues, select a proportionate option, record reasons, communicate it fairly and mitigate residual harm under independent or administrative review.
- D. A legal prohibition removes an option from ordinary ethical choice, but technical legality does not automatically establish morality or propriety; officials must also test public purpose, equality, constitutional values, reasons and foreseeable institutional effects.

Answer: B

Explanation: A genuine dilemma conflicts legitimate duties is the controlling principle. An ethical dilemma arises when two legitimate duties, values or loyalties cannot both be fully honoured; it differs from a simple temptation to obtain gain by breaking a known rule or disguising favouritism as compassion. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 19

A minister's preferred applicant technically meets minimum eligibility but is expedited outside the published queue. Which distinction must the officer apply? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An ethical dilemma arises when two legitimate duties, values or loyalties cannot both be fully honoured; it differs from a simple temptation to obtain gain by breaking a known rule or disguising favouritism as compassion.
- B. Dilemma resolution begins by identifying affected citizens, weaker groups, colleagues, institutions and future interests; mapping them exposes hidden burdens before an official chooses among lawful alternatives or invokes a public-good slogan.
- C. A legal prohibition removes an option from ordinary ethical choice, but technical legality does not automatically establish morality or propriety; officials must also test public purpose, equality, constitutional values, reasons and foreseeable institutional effects.
- D. After excluding unlawful options, an official should compare realistic alternatives through duties, consequences and virtues, select a proportionate option, record reasons, communicate it fairly and mitigate residual harm under independent or administrative review.

Answer: C

Explanation: Legality is a floor, not the whole ethical inquiry is the controlling principle. A legal prohibition removes an option from ordinary ethical choice, but technical legality does not automatically establish morality or propriety; officials must also test public purpose, equality, constitutional values, reasons and foreseeable institutional effects. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 20

A rule permits several lawful relief priorities. How should a collector choose among them without treating legality as a complete answer? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Dilemma resolution begins by identifying affected citizens, weaker groups, colleagues, institutions and future interests; mapping them exposes hidden burdens before an official chooses among lawful alternatives or invokes a public-good slogan.
- B. After excluding unlawful options, an official should compare realistic alternatives through duties, consequences and virtues, select a proportionate option, record reasons, communicate it fairly and mitigate residual harm under independent or administrative review.
- C. An ethical dilemma arises when two legitimate duties, values or loyalties cannot both be fully honoured; it differs from a simple temptation to obtain gain by breaking a known rule or disguising favouritism as compassion.
- D. A legal prohibition removes an option from ordinary ethical choice, but technical legality does not automatically establish morality or propriety; officials must also test public purpose, equality, constitutional values, reasons and foreseeable institutional effects.

Answer: D

Explanation: Legality is a floor, not the whole ethical inquiry is the controlling principle. A legal prohibition removes an option from ordinary ethical choice, but technical legality does not automatically establish morality or propriety; officials must also test public purpose, equality, constitutional values, reasons and foreseeable institutional effects. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 21

A city proposes clearing a forest edge for housing. Which step prevents electricity benefits from obscuring tribal livelihood and ecological costs? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Dilemma resolution begins by identifying affected citizens, weaker groups, colleagues, institutions and future interests; mapping them exposes hidden burdens before an official chooses among lawful alternatives or invokes a public-good slogan.
- B. An ethical dilemma arises when two legitimate duties, values or loyalties cannot both be fully honoured; it differs from a simple temptation to obtain gain by breaking a known rule or disguising favouritism as compassion.
- C. A legal prohibition removes an option from ordinary ethical choice, but technical legality does not automatically establish morality or propriety; officials must also test public purpose, equality, constitutional values, reasons and foreseeable institutional effects.
- D. After excluding unlawful options, an official should compare realistic alternatives through duties, consequences and virtues, select a proportionate option, record reasons, communicate it fairly and mitigate residual harm under independent or administrative review.

Answer: A

Explanation: Stakeholder mapping prevents tunnel vision is the controlling principle. Dilemma resolution begins by identifying affected citizens, weaker groups, colleagues, institutions and future interests; mapping them exposes hidden burdens before an official chooses among lawful alternatives or invokes a public-good slogan. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 22

A hospital administrator reallocates staff during an outbreak. Which diagnostic method ensures workers, patients and continuity of other care are considered? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A legal prohibition removes an option from ordinary ethical choice, but technical legality does not automatically establish morality or propriety; officials must also test public purpose, equality, constitutional values, reasons and foreseeable institutional effects.
- B. Dilemma resolution begins by identifying affected citizens, weaker groups, colleagues, institutions and future interests; mapping them exposes hidden burdens before an official chooses among lawful alternatives or invokes a public-good slogan.
- C. After excluding unlawful options, an official should compare realistic alternatives through duties, consequences and virtues, select a proportionate option, record reasons, communicate it fairly and mitigate residual harm under independent or administrative review.
- D. An ethical dilemma arises when two legitimate duties, values or loyalties cannot both be fully honoured; it differs from a simple temptation to obtain gain by breaking a known rule or disguising favouritism as compassion.

Answer: B

Explanation: Stakeholder mapping prevents tunnel vision is the controlling principle. Dilemma resolution begins by identifying affected citizens, weaker groups, colleagues, institutions and future interests; mapping them exposes hidden burdens before an official chooses among lawful alternatives or invokes a public-good slogan. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 23

A collector makes an emergency departure from normal documentation requirements. What sequence keeps the choice from becoming arbitrary discretion? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An ethical dilemma arises when two legitimate duties, values or loyalties cannot both be fully honoured; it differs from a simple temptation to obtain gain by breaking a known rule or disguising favouritism as compassion.
- B. A legal prohibition removes an option from ordinary ethical choice, but technical legality does not automatically establish morality or propriety; officials must also test public purpose, equality, constitutional values, reasons and foreseeable institutional effects.
- C. After excluding unlawful options, an official should compare realistic alternatives through duties, consequences and virtues, select a proportionate option, record reasons, communicate it fairly and mitigate residual harm under independent or administrative review.
- D. Dilemma resolution begins by identifying affected citizens, weaker groups, colleagues, institutions and future interests; mapping them exposes hidden burdens before an official chooses among lawful alternatives or invokes a public-good slogan.

Answer: C

Explanation: A defensible resolution is reasoned and reviewable is the controlling principle. After excluding unlawful options, an official should compare realistic alternatives through duties, consequences and virtues, select a proportionate option, record reasons, communicate it fairly and mitigate residual harm under independent or administrative review. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 24

A senior officer resolves a family-linked tender concern privately without a file note. What feature of defensible resolution is absent? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A legal prohibition removes an option from ordinary ethical choice, but technical legality does not automatically establish morality or propriety; officials must also test public purpose, equality, constitutional values, reasons and foreseeable institutional effects.
- B. Dilemma resolution begins by identifying affected citizens, weaker groups, colleagues, institutions and future interests; mapping them exposes hidden burdens before an official chooses among lawful alternatives or invokes a public-good slogan.
- C. An ethical dilemma arises when two legitimate duties, values or loyalties cannot both be fully honoured; it differs from a simple temptation to obtain gain by breaking a known rule or disguising favouritism as compassion.
- D. After excluding unlawful options, an official should compare realistic alternatives through duties, consequences and virtues, select a proportionate option, record reasons, communicate it fairly and mitigate residual harm under independent or administrative review.

Answer: D

Explanation: A defensible resolution is reasoned and reviewable is the controlling principle. After excluding unlawful options, an official should compare realistic alternatives through duties, consequences and virtues, select a proportionate option, record reasons, communicate it fairly and mitigate residual harm under independent or administrative review. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 25

A procurement officer's sibling submits a bid being evaluated by that officer. Which conflict type and operational response apply? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An actual conflict exists when a private interest and an immediate official decision directly collide; the normal safeguard is prompt declaration, removal from the particular decision and reassignment, rather than waiting to prove corrupt motive or outcome.
- B. A potential conflict is a private interest that could later intersect with official duty; proactive disclosure and a register enable later screening, while automatic present recusal is unnecessary where no relevant decision is before the officer.
- C. An apparent conflict exists where a reasonable informed observer could suspect compromised judgment despite no proved private benefit; transparency, reasons and sometimes voluntary recusal preserve confidence without mechanically treating appearance as established corruption.
- D. Declaration is a necessary first safeguard but does not cleanse every conflict; the institution must assess materiality, decide recusal, reassignment or conditions, record the response and ensure the private interest cannot distort public decision-making.

Answer: A

Explanation: Actual conflict calls for recusal is the controlling principle. An actual conflict exists when a private interest and an immediate official decision directly collide; the normal safeguard is prompt declaration, removal from the particular decision and reassignment, rather than waiting to prove corrupt motive or outcome. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 26

A municipal chair says impartiality is enough despite deciding on her spouse's licence. Why is private assurance insufficient? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An apparent conflict exists where a reasonable informed observer could suspect compromised judgment despite no proved private benefit; transparency, reasons and sometimes voluntary recusal preserve confidence without mechanically treating appearance as established corruption.
- B. An actual conflict exists when a private interest and an immediate official decision directly collide; the normal safeguard is prompt declaration, removal from the particular decision and reassignment, rather than waiting to prove corrupt motive or outcome.
- C. Declaration is a necessary first safeguard but does not cleanse every conflict; the institution must assess materiality, decide recusal, reassignment or conditions, record the response and ensure the private interest cannot distort public decision-making.
- D. A potential conflict is a private interest that could later intersect with official duty; proactive disclosure and a register enable later screening, while automatic present recusal is unnecessary where no relevant decision is before the officer.

Answer: B

Explanation: Actual conflict calls for recusal is the controlling principle. An actual conflict exists when a private interest and an immediate official decision directly collide; the normal safeguard is prompt declaration, removal from the particular decision and reassignment, rather than waiting to prove corrupt motive or outcome. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 27

An officer owns shares in a sector she may later regulate but has no current file. Which proportionate management response is appropriate? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An actual conflict exists when a private interest and an immediate official decision directly collide; the normal safeguard is prompt declaration, removal from the particular decision and reassignment, rather than waiting to prove corrupt motive or outcome.
- B. An apparent conflict exists where a reasonable informed observer could suspect compromised judgment despite no proved private benefit; transparency, reasons and sometimes voluntary recusal preserve confidence without mechanically treating appearance as established corruption.
- C. A potential conflict is a private interest that could later intersect with official duty; proactive disclosure and a register enable later screening, while automatic present recusal is unnecessary where no relevant decision is before the officer.
- D. Declaration is a necessary first safeguard but does not cleanse every conflict; the institution must assess materiality, decide recusal, reassignment or conditions, record the response and ensure the private interest cannot distort public decision-making.

Answer: C

Explanation: Potential conflict is managed prospectively is the controlling principle. A potential conflict is a private interest that could later intersect with official duty; proactive disclosure and a register enable later screening, while automatic present recusal is unnecessary where no relevant decision is before the officer. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 28

A new regulator hides a spouse's consultancy because no tender is active today. Which conflict concept exposes the error? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An apparent conflict exists where a reasonable informed observer could suspect compromised judgment despite no proved private benefit; transparency, reasons and sometimes voluntary recusal preserve confidence without mechanically treating appearance as established corruption.
- B. Declaration is a necessary first safeguard but does not cleanse every conflict; the institution must assess materiality, decide recusal, reassignment or conditions, record the response and ensure the private interest cannot distort public decision-making.
- C. An actual conflict exists when a private interest and an immediate official decision directly collide; the normal safeguard is prompt declaration, removal from the particular decision and reassignment, rather than waiting to prove corrupt motive or outcome.
- D. A potential conflict is a private interest that could later intersect with official duty; proactive disclosure and a register enable later screening, while automatic present recusal is unnecessary where no relevant decision is before the officer.

Answer: D

Explanation: Potential conflict is managed prospectively is the controlling principle. A potential conflict is a private interest that could later intersect with official duty; proactive disclosure and a register enable later screening, while automatic present recusal is unnecessary where no relevant decision is before the officer. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 29

A childhood friend seeks a routine approval from an officer using published criteria. What confidence-focused analysis is needed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An apparent conflict exists where a reasonable informed observer could suspect compromised judgment despite no proved private benefit; transparency, reasons and sometimes voluntary recusal preserve confidence without mechanically treating appearance as established corruption.
- B. An actual conflict exists when a private interest and an immediate official decision directly collide; the normal safeguard is prompt declaration, removal from the particular decision and reassignment, rather than waiting to prove corrupt motive or outcome.
- C. A potential conflict is a private interest that could later intersect with official duty; proactive disclosure and a register enable later screening, while automatic present recusal is unnecessary where no relevant decision is before the officer.
- D. Declaration is a necessary first safeguard but does not cleanse every conflict; the institution must assess materiality, decide recusal, reassignment or conditions, record the response and ensure the private interest cannot distort public decision-making.

Answer: A

Explanation: Apparent conflict requires confidence protection is the controlling principle. An apparent conflict exists where a reasonable informed observer could suspect compromised judgment despite no proved private benefit; transparency, reasons and sometimes voluntary recusal preserve confidence without mechanically treating appearance as established corruption. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 30

A journalist alleges bias because an official studied with an applicant decades ago. Which response avoids both concealment and automatic guilt? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A potential conflict is a private interest that could later intersect with official duty; proactive disclosure and a register enable later screening, while automatic present recusal is unnecessary where no relevant decision is before the officer.
- B. An apparent conflict exists where a reasonable informed observer could suspect compromised judgment despite no proved private benefit; transparency, reasons and sometimes voluntary recusal preserve confidence without mechanically treating appearance as established corruption.
- C. Declaration is a necessary first safeguard but does not cleanse every conflict; the institution must assess materiality, decide recusal, reassignment or conditions, record the response and ensure the private interest cannot distort public decision-making.
- D. An actual conflict exists when a private interest and an immediate official decision directly collide; the normal safeguard is prompt declaration, removal from the particular decision and reassignment, rather than waiting to prove corrupt motive or outcome.

Answer: B

Explanation: Apparent conflict requires confidence protection is the controlling principle. An apparent conflict exists where a reasonable informed observer could suspect compromised judgment despite no proved private benefit; transparency, reasons and sometimes voluntary recusal preserve confidence without mechanically treating appearance as established corruption. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 31

A board member declares a major holding, then participates in regulating that company. Which management principle remains unmet? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An actual conflict exists when a private interest and an immediate official decision directly collide; the normal safeguard is prompt declaration, removal from the particular decision and reassignment, rather than waiting to prove corrupt motive or outcome.
- B. A potential conflict is a private interest that could later intersect with official duty; proactive disclosure and a register enable later screening, while automatic present recusal is unnecessary where no relevant decision is before the officer.
- C. Declaration is a necessary first safeguard but does not cleanse every conflict; the institution must assess materiality, decide recusal, reassignment or conditions, record the response and ensure the private interest cannot distort public decision-making.
- D. An apparent conflict exists where a reasonable informed observer could suspect compromised judgment despite no proved private benefit; transparency, reasons and sometimes voluntary recusal preserve confidence without mechanically treating appearance as established corruption.

Answer: C

Explanation: Disclosure does not itself resolve conflict is the controlling principle. Declaration is a necessary first safeguard but does not cleanse every conflict; the institution must assess materiality, decide recusal, reassignment or conditions, record the response and ensure the private interest cannot distort public decision-making. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 32

A district office maintains an interest register but never screens files against it. Why is the safeguard incomplete? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A potential conflict is a private interest that could later intersect with official duty; proactive disclosure and a register enable later screening, while automatic present recusal is unnecessary where no relevant decision is before the officer.
- B. An apparent conflict exists where a reasonable informed observer could suspect compromised judgment despite no proved private benefit; transparency, reasons and sometimes voluntary recusal preserve confidence without mechanically treating appearance as established corruption.
- C. An actual conflict exists when a private interest and an immediate official decision directly collide; the normal safeguard is prompt declaration, removal from the particular decision and reassignment, rather than waiting to prove corrupt motive or outcome.
- D. Declaration is a necessary first safeguard but does not cleanse every conflict; the institution must assess materiality, decide recusal, reassignment or conditions, record the response and ensure the private interest cannot distort public decision-making.

Answer: D

Explanation: Disclosure does not itself resolve conflict is the controlling principle. Declaration is a necessary first safeguard but does not cleanse every conflict; the institution must assess materiality, decide recusal, reassignment or conditions, record the response and ensure the private interest cannot distort public decision-making. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 33

A superior threatens an adverse appraisal unless a junior certifies an unsafe building. Which workplace-power concept applies? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Coercion compels conduct through an explicit or implicit threat of harm, such as punitive transfer, dismissal or retaliation; apparent consent under such duress is not a reliable ethical defence for the pressured official or decision.
- B. Undue influence exploits trust, authority or dependency to bend another's autonomous judgment without an overt threat; it requires attention to relationship patterns, career vulnerability and informal pressure rather than only searching for a provable quid pro quo.
- C. Discretion is not personal freedom: it must stay within authority, pursue statutory and constitutional purpose, use relevant facts and equal criteria, remain proportionate and be documented so that citizens, supervisors and courts can review it.
- D. Automating rule-bound services can reduce arbitrary discretion and improve traceability, but accountable administration still requires accessible alternatives, human review of exclusion, reliable data and responsibility for biased design, implementation and redress.

Answer: A

Explanation: Coercion overbears choice through threat is the controlling principle. Coercion compels conduct through an explicit or implicit threat of harm, such as punitive transfer, dismissal or retaliation; apparent consent under such duress is not a reliable ethical defence for the pressured official or decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 34

A ministerial aide threatens to block an officer's transfer unless a file is expedited. What makes this more than firm instruction? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Discretion is not personal freedom: it must stay within authority, pursue statutory and constitutional purpose, use relevant facts and equal criteria, remain proportionate and be documented so that citizens, supervisors and courts can review it.
- B. Coercion compels conduct through an explicit or implicit threat of harm, such as punitive transfer, dismissal or retaliation; apparent consent under such duress is not a reliable ethical defence for the pressured official or decision.
- C. Automating rule-bound services can reduce arbitrary discretion and improve traceability, but accountable administration still requires accessible alternatives, human review of exclusion, reliable data and responsibility for biased design, implementation and redress.
- D. Undue influence exploits trust, authority or dependency to bend another's autonomous judgment without an overt threat; it requires attention to relationship patterns, career vulnerability and informal pressure rather than only searching for a provable quid pro quo.

Answer: B

Explanation: Coercion overbears choice through threat is the controlling principle. Coercion compels conduct through an explicit or implicit threat of harm, such as punitive transfer, dismissal or retaliation; apparent consent under such duress is not a reliable ethical defence for the pressured official or decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 35

A mentor repeatedly hints that a junior's promotion depends on selecting a preferred vendor. Which power abuse is present? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Coercion compels conduct through an explicit or implicit threat of harm, such as punitive transfer, dismissal or retaliation; apparent consent under such duress is not a reliable ethical defence for the pressured official or decision.
- B. Discretion is not personal freedom: it must stay within authority, pursue statutory and constitutional purpose, use relevant facts and equal criteria, remain proportionate and be documented so that citizens, supervisors and courts can review it.
- C. Undue influence exploits trust, authority or dependency to bend another's autonomous judgment without an overt threat; it requires attention to relationship patterns, career vulnerability and informal pressure rather than only searching for a provable quid pro quo.
- D. Automating rule-bound services can reduce arbitrary discretion and improve traceability, but accountable administration still requires accessible alternatives, human review of exclusion, reliable data and responsibility for biased design, implementation and redress.

Answer: C

Explanation: Undue influence exploits dependency without threat is the controlling principle. Undue influence exploits trust, authority or dependency to bend another's autonomous judgment without an overt threat; it requires attention to relationship patterns, career vulnerability and informal pressure rather than only searching for a provable quid pro quo. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 36

A retiring regulator cultivates a future job from a recently supervised firm without an express bargain. Which ethical risk needs scrutiny? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Discretion is not personal freedom: it must stay within authority, pursue statutory and constitutional purpose, use relevant facts and equal criteria, remain proportionate and be documented so that citizens, supervisors and courts can review it.
- B. Automating rule-bound services can reduce arbitrary discretion and improve traceability, but accountable administration still requires accessible alternatives, human review of exclusion, reliable data and responsibility for biased design, implementation and redress.
- C. Coercion compels conduct through an explicit or implicit threat of harm, such as punitive transfer, dismissal or retaliation; apparent consent under such duress is not a reliable ethical defence for the pressured official or decision.
- D. Undue influence exploits trust, authority or dependency to bend another's autonomous judgment without an overt threat; it requires attention to relationship patterns, career vulnerability and informal pressure rather than only searching for a provable quid pro quo.

Answer: D

Explanation: Undue influence exploits dependency without threat is the controlling principle. Undue influence exploits trust, authority or dependency to bend another's autonomous judgment without an overt threat; it requires attention to relationship patterns, career vulnerability and informal pressure rather than only searching for a provable quid pro quo. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 37

A flood officer accepts equivalent proof from every applicant whose papers were destroyed. What conditions make this calibrated discretion rather than favour? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Discretion is not personal freedom: it must stay within authority, pursue statutory and constitutional purpose, use relevant facts and equal criteria, remain proportionate and be documented so that citizens, supervisors and courts can review it.
- B. Coercion compels conduct through an explicit or implicit threat of harm, such as punitive transfer, dismissal or retaliation; apparent consent under such duress is not a reliable ethical defence for the pressured official or decision.
- C. Undue influence exploits trust, authority or dependency to bend another's autonomous judgment without an overt threat; it requires attention to relationship patterns, career vulnerability and informal pressure rather than only searching for a provable quid pro quo.
- D. Automating rule-bound services can reduce arbitrary discretion and improve traceability, but accountable administration still requires accessible alternatives, human review of exclusion, reliable data and responsibility for biased design, implementation and redress.

Answer: A

Explanation: Discretion needs legal purpose and recorded reasons is the controlling principle. Discretion is not personal freedom: it must stay within authority, pursue statutory and constitutional purpose, use relevant facts and equal criteria, remain proportionate and be documented so that citizens, supervisors and courts can review it. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 38

A licensing official waives documents only for politically connected applicants. Which controls on discretion have failed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Undue influence exploits trust, authority or dependency to bend another's autonomous judgment without an overt threat; it requires attention to relationship patterns, career vulnerability and informal pressure rather than only searching for a provable quid pro quo.
- B. Discretion is not personal freedom: it must stay within authority, pursue statutory and constitutional purpose, use relevant facts and equal criteria, remain proportionate and be documented so that citizens, supervisors and courts can review it.
- C. Automating rule-bound services can reduce arbitrary discretion and improve traceability, but accountable administration still requires accessible alternatives, human review of exclusion, reliable data and responsibility for biased design, implementation and redress.
- D. Coercion compels conduct through an explicit or implicit threat of harm, such as punitive transfer, dismissal or retaliation; apparent consent under such duress is not a reliable ethical defence for the pressured official or decision.

Answer: B

Explanation: Discretion needs legal purpose and recorded reasons is the controlling principle. Discretion is not personal freedom: it must stay within authority, pursue statutory and constitutional purpose, use relevant facts and equal criteria, remain proportionate and be documented so that citizens, supervisors and courts can review it. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 39

A digital benefit portal rejects persons whose biometric authentication fails repeatedly. What accountability safeguard must accompany automation? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Coercion compels conduct through an explicit or implicit threat of harm, such as punitive transfer, dismissal or retaliation; apparent consent under such duress is not a reliable ethical defence for the pressured official or decision.
- B. Undue influence exploits trust, authority or dependency to bend another's autonomous judgment without an overt threat; it requires attention to relationship patterns, career vulnerability and informal pressure rather than only searching for a provable quid pro quo.
- C. Automating rule-bound services can reduce arbitrary discretion and improve traceability, but accountable administration still requires accessible alternatives, human review of exclusion, reliable data and responsibility for biased design, implementation and redress.
- D. Discretion is not personal freedom: it must stay within authority, pursue statutory and constitutional purpose, use relevant facts and equal criteria, remain proportionate and be documented so that citizens, supervisors and courts can review it.

Answer: C

Explanation: Automation can reduce but not erase accountability is the controlling principle. Automating rule-bound services can reduce arbitrary discretion and improve traceability, but accountable administration still requires accessible alternatives, human review of exclusion, reliable data and responsibility for biased design, implementation and redress. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 40

A department claims its algorithm makes recruitment fully objective. Which ethical qualification should a review committee insist upon? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Undue influence exploits trust, authority or dependency to bend another's autonomous judgment without an overt threat; it requires attention to relationship patterns, career vulnerability and informal pressure rather than only searching for a provable quid pro quo.
- B. Discretion is not personal freedom: it must stay within authority, pursue statutory and constitutional purpose, use relevant facts and equal criteria, remain proportionate and be documented so that citizens, supervisors and courts can review it.
- C. Coercion compels conduct through an explicit or implicit threat of harm, such as punitive transfer, dismissal or retaliation; apparent consent under such duress is not a reliable ethical defence for the pressured official or decision.
- D. Automating rule-bound services can reduce arbitrary discretion and improve traceability, but accountable administration still requires accessible alternatives, human review of exclusion, reliable data and responsibility for biased design, implementation and redress.

Answer: D

Explanation: Automation can reduce but not erase accountability is the controlling principle. Automating rule-bound services can reduce arbitrary discretion and improve traceability, but accountable administration still requires accessible alternatives, human review of exclusion, reliable data and responsibility for biased design, implementation and redress. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 41

A disaster authority withholds exact shelter locations temporarily because disclosure would expose women to a verified security risk. Which value balance is required? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nolan openness favours maximum disclosure, but information may be restricted when a clear wider public-interest and lawful ground supports it; secrecy must be justified, narrowly tailored and not used to conceal embarrassment, favouritism or maladministration.
- B. In the Nolan formulation, honesty specifically requires declaration of private interests relating to public duties and resolution of resulting conflicts; ordinary truthfulness remains important, but this principle directly targets transparent conflict management.
- C. Nolan leadership requires senior office holders to promote public-life values through personal example, fair systems and response to misconduct; ethical culture cannot be created by slogans while leaders reward target achievement obtained through improper means.
- D. Disposal, pendency and response-time metrics can make administrative monitoring visible, but they do not by themselves prove correctness, fairness, satisfaction, impartiality or absence of misconduct; qualitative review and remedy remain necessary.

Answer: A

Explanation: Openness has a justified public-interest limit is the controlling principle. Nolan openness favours maximum disclosure, but information may be restricted when a clear wider public-interest and lawful ground supports it; secrecy must be justified, narrowly tailored and not used to conceal embarrassment, favouritism or maladministration. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 42

A department refuses an audit request solely because criticism may embarrass a minister. Why is this not a valid openness exception? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nolan leadership requires senior office holders to promote public-life values through personal example, fair systems and response to misconduct; ethical culture cannot be created by slogans while leaders reward target achievement obtained through improper means.
- B. Nolan openness favours maximum disclosure, but information may be restricted when a clear wider public-interest and lawful ground supports it; secrecy must be justified, narrowly tailored and not used to conceal embarrassment, favouritism or maladministration.
- C. Disposal, pendency and response-time metrics can make administrative monitoring visible, but they do not by themselves prove correctness, fairness, satisfaction, impartiality or absence of misconduct; qualitative review and remedy remain necessary.
- D. In the Nolan formulation, honesty specifically requires declaration of private interests relating to public duties and resolution of resulting conflicts; ordinary truthfulness remains important, but this principle directly targets transparent conflict management.

Answer: B

Explanation: Openness has a justified public-interest limit is the controlling principle. Nolan openness favours maximum disclosure, but information may be restricted when a clear wider public-interest and lawful ground supports it; secrecy must be justified, narrowly tailored and not used to conceal embarrassment, favouritism or maladministration. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 43

A committee member accurately reports project data but conceals a relative's consultancy with the vendor. Which Nolan requirement is breached? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nolan openness favours maximum disclosure, but information may be restricted when a clear wider public-interest and lawful ground supports it; secrecy must be justified, narrowly tailored and not used to conceal embarrassment, favouritism or maladministration.
- B. Nolan leadership requires senior office holders to promote public-life values through personal example, fair systems and response to misconduct; ethical culture cannot be created by slogans while leaders reward target achievement obtained through improper means.
- C. In the Nolan formulation, honesty specifically requires declaration of private interests relating to public duties and resolution of resulting conflicts; ordinary truthfulness remains important, but this principle directly targets transparent conflict management.
- D. Disposal, pendency and response-time metrics can make administrative monitoring visible, but they do not by themselves prove correctness, fairness, satisfaction, impartiality or absence of misconduct; qualitative review and remedy remain necessary.

Answer: C

Explanation: Honesty includes private-interest declaration is the controlling principle. In the Nolan formulation, honesty specifically requires declaration of private interests relating to public duties and resolution of resulting conflicts; ordinary truthfulness remains important, but this principle directly targets transparent conflict management. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 44

An officer voluntarily places a financial interest on record before joining a regulatory panel. Which public-life value is being applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nolan leadership requires senior office holders to promote public-life values through personal example, fair systems and response to misconduct; ethical culture cannot be created by slogans while leaders reward target achievement obtained through improper means.
- B. Disposal, pendency and response-time metrics can make administrative monitoring visible, but they do not by themselves prove correctness, fairness, satisfaction, impartiality or absence of misconduct; qualitative review and remedy remain necessary.
- C. Nolan openness favours maximum disclosure, but information may be restricted when a clear wider public-interest and lawful ground supports it; secrecy must be justified, narrowly tailored and not used to conceal embarrassment, favouritism or maladministration.
- D. In the Nolan formulation, honesty specifically requires declaration of private interests relating to public duties and resolution of resulting conflicts; ordinary truthfulness remains important, but this principle directly targets transparent conflict management.

Answer: D

Explanation: Honesty includes private-interest declaration is the controlling principle. In the Nolan formulation, honesty specifically requires declaration of private interests relating to public duties and resolution of resulting conflicts; ordinary truthfulness remains important, but this principle directly targets transparent conflict management. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 45

A department head refuses to reward staff who manipulate beneficiary data to meet targets. Which Nolan principle is being demonstrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nolan leadership requires senior office holders to promote public-life values through personal example, fair systems and response to misconduct; ethical culture cannot be created by slogans while leaders reward target achievement obtained through improper means.
- B. Nolan openness favours maximum disclosure, but information may be restricted when a clear wider public-interest and lawful ground supports it; secrecy must be justified, narrowly tailored and not used to conceal embarrassment, favouritism or maladministration.
- C. In the Nolan formulation, honesty specifically requires declaration of private interests relating to public duties and resolution of resulting conflicts; ordinary truthfulness remains important, but this principle directly targets transparent conflict management.
- D. Disposal, pendency and response-time metrics can make administrative monitoring visible, but they do not by themselves prove correctness, fairness, satisfaction, impartiality or absence of misconduct; qualitative review and remedy remain necessary.

Answer: A

Explanation: Leadership shapes institutional ethical climate is the controlling principle. Nolan leadership requires senior office holders to promote public-life values through personal example, fair systems and response to misconduct; ethical culture cannot be created by slogans while leaders reward target achievement obtained through improper means. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 46

A senior officer signs a conflict declaration, protects dissenters and reviews procurement reasons. How does this build ethical climate? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. In the Nolan formulation, honesty specifically requires declaration of private interests relating to public duties and resolution of resulting conflicts; ordinary truthfulness remains important, but this principle directly targets transparent conflict management.
- B. Nolan leadership requires senior office holders to promote public-life values through personal example, fair systems and response to misconduct; ethical culture cannot be created by slogans while leaders reward target achievement obtained through improper means.
- C. Disposal, pendency and response-time metrics can make administrative monitoring visible, but they do not by themselves prove correctness, fairness, satisfaction, impartiality or absence of misconduct; qualitative review and remedy remain necessary.
- D. Nolan openness favours maximum disclosure, but information may be restricted when a clear wider public-interest and lawful ground supports it; secrecy must be justified, narrowly tailored and not used to conceal embarrassment, favouritism or maladministration.

Answer: B

Explanation: Leadership shapes institutional ethical climate is the controlling principle. Nolan leadership requires senior office holders to promote public-life values through personal example, fair systems and response to misconduct; ethical culture cannot be created by slogans while leaders reward target achievement obtained through improper means. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 47

A ministry closes one lakh grievance records quickly but gives identical non-speaking replies. Which distinction prevents equating speed with accountability? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Nolan openness favours maximum disclosure, but information may be restricted when a clear wider public-interest and lawful ground supports it; secrecy must be justified, narrowly tailored and not used to conceal embarrassment, favouritism or maladministration.
- B. In the Nolan formulation, honesty specifically requires declaration of private interests relating to public duties and resolution of resulting conflicts; ordinary truthfulness remains important, but this principle directly targets transparent conflict management.
- C. Disposal, pendency and response-time metrics can make administrative monitoring visible, but they do not by themselves prove correctness, fairness, satisfaction, impartiality or absence of misconduct; qualitative review and remedy remain necessary.
- D. Nolan leadership requires senior office holders to promote public-life values through personal example, fair systems and response to misconduct; ethical culture cannot be created by slogans while leaders reward target achievement obtained through improper means.

Answer: C

Explanation: Metrics illustrate monitoring, not complete ethics is the controlling principle. Disposal, pendency and response-time metrics can make administrative monitoring visible, but they do not by themselves prove correctness, fairness, satisfaction, impartiality or absence of misconduct; qualitative review and remedy remain necessary. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 48

A dashboard shows low pendency while inaccessible digital procedures exclude elderly claimants. What ethical limitation of metrics is exposed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

A. In the Nolan formulation, honesty specifically requires declaration of private interests relating to public duties and resolution of resulting conflicts; ordinary truthfulness remains important, but this principle directly targets transparent conflict management.

B. Nolan leadership requires senior office holders to promote public-life values through personal example, fair systems and response to misconduct; ethical culture cannot be created by slogans while leaders reward target achievement obtained through improper means.

C. Nolan openness favours maximum disclosure, but information may be restricted when a clear wider public-interest and lawful ground supports it; secrecy must be justified, narrowly tailored and not used to conceal embarrassment, favouritism or maladministration.

D. Disposal, pendency and response-time metrics can make administrative monitoring visible, but they do not by themselves prove correctness, fairness, satisfaction, impartiality or absence of misconduct; qualitative review and remedy remain necessary.

Answer: D

Explanation: Metrics illustrate monitoring, not complete ethics is the controlling principle. Disposal, pendency and response-time metrics can make administrative monitoring visible, but they do not by themselves prove correctness, fairness, satisfaction, impartiality or absence of misconduct; qualitative review and remedy remain necessary. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q2(a): What is meant by public interest? What are the principles and procedures to be followed by civil servants in public interest? 10 marks; 150 words.

Source / ownership: Exact wording verified against books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf. Topic 09 owns public-service values; RTI in Q2(b) belongs primarily to Topic 15.

Model solution

Public interest is constitutionally permissible, evidence-based welfare rather than a private, partisan or majoritarian preference. It includes the interests of weaker, remote and future citizens who may not be able to exert immediate political pressure. A civil servant should identify affected groups, act within law and delegated authority, use relevant evidence, apply published criteria equally, disclose conflicts, consult where feasible and record reasons capable of review. In disaster relief, need, vulnerability and access constraints should guide allocation rather than political connection or media visibility. A workable appeal channel can correct exclusion without suspending urgent delivery. Integrity prevents private capture, impartiality protects equal treatment, and accountability makes the decision publicly defensible. Thus public interest is neither an officer's private moral preference nor a numerical count of demands; it is a reasoned constitutional judgment about common welfare.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q3(a): What is meant by conflict of interest? Illustrate with examples the difference between actual and potential conflicts of interest. 10 marks; 150 words.

Source / ownership: Exact wording verified against the local 2018 GS-IV paper. Topic 09 is the direct owner; apparent conflict is useful supplementary teaching, not a substituted PYQ demand.

Model solution

A conflict of interest is a private interest capable of improperly influencing public duty, or reasonably appearing to do so. It is a risk situation, not by itself proof of corruption. An actual conflict is immediate: a procurement officer evaluates a sibling's bid. It requires prompt declaration, recusal from that decision and reassignment to an independent colleague. A potential conflict may arise later: a regulator owns shares in a sector she may subsequently supervise. It requires advance disclosure and an interest register so that later files can be screened. The distinction enables proportionate prevention: ignoring a potential interest loses an early safeguard, while treating every remote interest as an actual conflict can paralyse service delivery. Concealment, participation despite a material conflict and failure to follow prescribed management measures threaten integrity, equal treatment and public confidence.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(b): Explain the process of resolving ethical dilemmas in Public Administration. 10 marks; 150 words.

Source / ownership: Exact wording verified against the local 2018 GS-IV paper. Topic 09 supplies diagnosis; the full Section-B answer architecture is owned by Topic 22.

Model solution

First distinguish a genuine clash of legitimate duties from a simple illegal, corrupt or self-interested proposal. Establish the material facts, affected stakeholders, authority, time pressure and legal floor; options barred by law ordinarily drop out. Then generate realistic alternatives rather than comparing action only with inaction. Test each through rights and equality, public interest, foreseeable consequences, institutional precedent, integrity and the character expected of a public servant. Select the proportionate option, state reasons, communicate it respectfully and mitigate foreseeable residual harm. In a relief conflict between speed and verification, a temporary, uniformly available alternative-proof mechanism may protect both life and fairness. It should be time-bound, documented and reviewable. Consultation, a clear handover of responsibility and an appeal route improve implementation. Record and review make the decision accountable rather than privately intuitive or merely expedient.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2019 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q1(a): What are the basic principles of public life? Illustrate any three with suitable examples. 10 marks; 150 words.

Source / ownership: Exact wording verified against

books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf. It is shared with Topic 04; use the Nolan principles as ARC-cited public-life evidence, not as India-specific rules.

Model solution

The ARC reproduces the Nolan principles: selflessness, integrity, objectivity, accountability, openness, honesty and leadership. Selflessness means a district officer allocates relief by need, not electoral benefit. Integrity means a tender member declares a relative's interest and recuses before evaluation. Objectivity means appointments, contracts and benefits use published merit criteria rather than influence. Accountability requires recorded reasons, appropriate scrutiny and correction where a decision is defective. Openness favours disclosure unless a clear lawful public-interest ground justifies restriction; honesty includes declaring relevant private interests. Leadership requires seniors to model these standards and build systems that do not reward improper target achievement. These principles connect power with public trust. They should be joined to Indian constitutional equality, dignity and lawful procedure rather than copied as a free-standing or India-specific foreign checklist.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2019 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q1(b): What do you understand by the term 'public servant'? Reflect on the expected role of a public servant. 10 marks; 150 words.

Source / ownership: Exact wording verified against the local 2019 GS-IV paper. Shared with Topic 04; do not duplicate its aptitude/foundational-values treatment.

Model solution

A public servant exercises entrusted state authority to advance lawful public purposes. The role is neither personal patronage nor passive file movement: it requires competence, impartial and citizen-respectful implementation, frank non-partisan advice, protection of constitutional rights, prudent discretion and answerability for reasons and outcomes. A secretary should advise a minister honestly, flag legal or ethical difficulty through recorded channels, suggest workable lawful alternatives and loyally implement the lawful final decision without favour or fear. A field officer should also make services accessible to those facing disability, distance or documentation barriers, while treating comparable applicants by the same criteria. Public status therefore brings higher expectations of integrity, propriety and restraint in private relationships. The official is accountable for delivery and process, whereas the elected executive remains democratically answerable for broad policy choices. This balance safeguards both democratic mandate and professional neutrality.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q2(b): Besides domain knowledge, a public official needs innovativeness and creativity of a high order while resolving ethical dilemmas. Discuss with suitable example. 10 marks; 150 words.

Source / ownership: Exact wording verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-21-GENSTUDIESPAPER-IV-110122.pdf. Shared with Topic 13 for technology; innovation remains bounded by law, equality and review.

Model solution

Innovation helps an official avoid false binaries without evading ethical constraints. In flood relief, a collector can use mobile verification, community lists, assisted offline help and a time-bound appeal desk when documents are destroyed, instead of choosing between total exclusion and fabricated records. Creativity widens feasible options; it does not create authority to favour individuals, hide reasons or bypass rights. The officer must confirm delegated authority, identify vulnerable groups, apply the alternative equally to comparable claimants and disclose the temporary criteria. Consultation with local bodies can expose error, while audit trails protect against duplication and capture. The measure should have a clear review date and normal safeguards should be restored when emergency conditions end. Thus ethical innovation is principled, evidence-responsive problem-solving: it reconciles service delivery with integrity rather than treating compassion as a licence for irregularity.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2023 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q2(b): In the context of work environment, differentiate between 'coercion' and 'undue influence' with suitable examples. 10 marks; 150 words.

Source / ownership: Exact wording verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-23-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV-180923.pdf. Topic 09 direct route.

Model solution

Coercion overbears choice through an explicit or implicit threat: a superior threatens a punitive transfer, dismissal or adverse appraisal unless a junior certifies unsafe work. Any apparent consent is impaired by fear. Undue influence exploits trust, authority or dependency without an overt threat: a mentor repeatedly links career goodwill to choosing a preferred vendor, making independent judgment difficult. Coercion is often incident-specific and more readily evidenced through the identified threat; undue influence is more likely to require pattern review of relationships, repeated favours and career vulnerability. Both corrupt autonomous professional judgment and may distort public decisions. Safeguards include protected reporting, written directions, independent appraisal, separation of conflicted decision-makers, rotation where necessary and recorded reasons for discretionary recommendations. An ethics response should not label every firm lawful instruction coercion, but must not dismiss subtle dependency pressure as ordinary professional advice.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2024 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(a): The 'Code of Conduct' and 'Code of Ethics' are sources of guidance in public administration. There is a Code of Conduct already in operation whereas a Code of Ethics is not yet put in place. Suggest a suitable model for a Code of Ethics to maintain integrity, probity and transparency in governance. 10 marks; 150 words.

Source / ownership: Exact wording and format verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf. Topic 16 is the dedicated primary owner; Topic 09 supplies Nolan/public-service-values support. Treat the question premise as a PYQ premise, not proof of every category's current legal status.

Model solution

A Code of Ethics should begin with constitutional fidelity and public purpose, then require selflessness, integrity, merit objectivity, impartiality, openness, honest interest declaration, accountability and leadership by example. It should address gifts, conflicts, post-employment, reasoned discretion, treatment of citizens, use of information and protection of good-faith dissent. Its provisions should be intelligible to citizens as well as officials. Operational support is essential: public declaration, confidential ethics advice, periodic training, updated interest registers, independent complaint handling, fair inquiry and an annual public report on observance. A separate Code of Conduct can specify service rules, procedures and consequences; an ethics code cannot replace legal safeguards. The ARC's Nolan-based distinction therefore supports principles joined to implementation, monitoring and leadership, rather than a symbolic document or an unverified claim about every public-office category's present status.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(a): "One who is devoted to one's duty attains highest perfection in life." Analyse this statement with reference to sense of responsibility and personal fulfilment as a civil servant. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact wording and format verified against books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf. Shared with Topic 04; do not treat devotion as blind obedience or self-erasure.

Model solution

Devotion to duty gives a civil servant purpose, reliability and satisfaction from advancing public welfare. It means competent, timely and impartial discharge of entrusted responsibility, not obedience to every informal demand or pursuit of visible targets at any cost. A disaster officer who remains accessible, protects vulnerable citizens, coordinates teams and records fair allocation decisions may experience fulfilment through meaningful service. Yet duty must be constitutional and sustainable: blind obedience can enable illegality, while relentless self-sacrifice can impair judgment, health and legitimate family obligations. In a personal emergency, responsible delegation and transparent communication may better serve citizens than either abandonment of duty or performative self-denial. Personal fulfilment is deepest when commitment joins integrity, empathy, lawful discretion, professional competence and accountable institutional support. It is the satisfaction of serving a public purpose well, not a claim to moral superiority over citizens or colleagues.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(b): To achieve holistic development goal, a civil servant acts as an enabler and active facilitator of growth rather than a regulator. What specific measures will you suggest to achieve this goal? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact wording and format verified against the local 2025 GS-IV paper and routing ledger. Shared with Topic 04; Topic 09 adds public-trust, impartiality and accountability limits.

Model solution

An enabler removes lawful barriers that prevent citizens from accessing rights and services; a facilitator coordinates agencies, information and participation to make policy work. A district officer can provide accessible grievance channels, help self-help groups complete applications, arrange language or disability support and coordinate departments after a disaster. This strengthens citizen capability rather than creating dependence on a personal patron. Facilitation is not patronage: comparable citizens need equal criteria, decisions need intelligible reasons, and private intermediaries cannot capture discretion. The official should verify authority, publish service standards, retain an audit trail and offer review where a person is excluded. The ethical role combines empathy with objectivity, initiative with lawful authority, and responsiveness with accountability. It shifts administration from command alone to citizen-capability building while retaining public trust and preventing selective convenience from becoming favouritism.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2025 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q7 case study: Vijay was Deputy Commissioner of remote district of Hilly Northern State of the country for the last two years. In the month of August heavy rains lashed the complete state followed by cloud burst in the upper reaches of the said district. The damage was very heavy in the complete state especially in the affected district. The complete road network and telecommunication were disrupted and the buildings were damaged extensively. People's houses have been destroyed and they were forced to stay in open. More than 200 people have been killed and about 5000 were badly injured. The Civil Administration under Vijay got activated and started conducting rescue and relief operations. Temporary shelter camps and hospitals were established to provide shelter and medical facilities to the homeless and injured people. Helicopter services were pressed in, for evacuating sick and old people from remote areas. Vijay got a message from his hometown in Kerala that his mother was seriously sick. After two days Vijay received the unfortunate message that his mother has expired. Vijay has no close relative except one elder sister who was US citizen and staying there for last several years. In the meantime, the situation in the affected district deteriorated further due to resumption of heavy rains after a gap of five days. At the same time, continuous messages were coming on his mobile from his hometown to reach at the earliest for performing last rites of his mother. (a) What are the options available with Vijay? (b) What are the ethical dilemma being faced by Vijay? (c) Critically evaluate and examine each of these options identified by Vijay. (d) Which of the options, do you think, would be most appropriate for Vijay to adopt and why? (Answer in 250 words)

Source / ownership: Full case facts, all four demands and the single 250-word format reproduced from books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf. Topic 09 owns multi-duty diagnosis; Topic 22 owns the complete case-answer architecture.

Model solution

Vijay may remain throughout; leave immediately; stabilise and delegate before a brief visit; or participate remotely and travel after the crisis. The stakeholders are disaster-affected citizens, rescue staff, administration, his family and Vijay himself. The dilemma is public duty to protect lives versus filial, cultural and personal obligation; it also involves whether delegation is responsible leadership or abandonment, fair relief allocation and transparent crisis communication. Remaining offers command continuity, reassurance and rapid coordination but exacts grave personal cost and risks impaired judgment through unacknowledged grief. Immediate departure respects last rites but may endanger a fragile operation where roads and communications have failed. A brief absence is defensible only with a competent written handover, communication redundancy, authority clarity, resource access and a recall threshold. Remote rites protect operations but may insufficiently meet family duty. Vijay should immediately stabilise command, notify superiors, assess the deputy's competence and delegate in writing to the strongest available officer. He should brief teams and the public on the continuity arrangement, while protecting necessary family privacy. He must retain a

clear escalation channel and periodically reassess whether delegated command remains adequate. He may travel only if operations are demonstrably stable; otherwise he should remain and arrange remote participation, with later institutional support for travel. Consequence analysis gives special weight to avoidable mass harm; duty ethics recognises family obligation; virtue requires compassion with practical wisdom. This preserves life-saving duty without treating private grief as ethically irrelevant.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2025 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q12 case study: Ashok is Divisional Commissioner of one of the border districts of the North East State. A few years back, Military has taken over the neighbouring country after overthrowing the elected civil government. Civil war situation is prevailing in the country especially in last two years. However, internal situation further deteriorated due to rebel groups taking over control of certain populated areas near own border. Due to intense fight between military and rebel groups, civilian casualties has increased manifold in recent past. In the meantime, in one night Ashok got information from the local police guarding the border check post that there are about 200-250 people mainly women and children trying to cross over to our side of the border. There are also about 10 soldiers with their weapons in military uniform part of this group who wants to cross over. Women and Children are also crying and begging for help. A few of them are injured and bleeding profusely need immediate medical care. Ashok tried to contact Home Secretary of the State but failed to do so due to poor connectivity mainly due to inclement weather. (a) What are the options available with Ashok to cope with the situation? (b) What are the ethical and legal dilemmas being faced by Ashok? (c) Which of the options, do you think would be more appropriate for Ashok to adopt and why? (d) In the present situation, what are the extra precautionary measures to be taken by the Border Guarding Police in dealing with soldiers in uniform? (Answer in 250 words)

Source / ownership: Full case facts, all four demands and the single 250-word format reproduced from books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf. Topic 09 supports ethical/legal dilemma diagnosis; Topic 22 controls full case methodology.

Model solution

Ashok can refuse entry; admit everyone without screening; provide emergency assistance while separating and screening groups; or hold civilians safely pending higher directions. Stakeholders include injured women and children, armed soldiers, local residents, border personnel, state authorities and persons on both sides of the border. He faces humanity and urgent medical care versus border security, legal authority, non-discrimination, public order and risk posed by armed personnel. Refusal risks preventable death and breaches the public servant's duty of care; unverified admission risks security and loss of control; delay without care is inhumane. The proportionate course is immediate life-saving aid and protected temporary shelter for civilians, gender- and child-sensitive registration, rapid communication with competent authorities, and individual rather than collective assessment. Armed soldiers should be disarmed, physically separated from civilians, searched lawfully, guarded by trained personnel, medically examined, documented and handled under applicable security and legal procedures without summary punishment. Separate interpreters, women officers and medical staff should reduce secondary harm and improve reliable assessment. Food, water, medical triage and safe shelter should not be withheld from civilians because armed persons are present. Ashok should record the emergency facts and decisions, seek instructions as soon as contact is restored and ensure staff use minimum necessary force. Subsequent independent review must test both humanitarian treatment and security procedure. This preserves dignity and impartiality while managing concrete risk through necessity, proportionality, reasons and review.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish public interest from majoritarian preference in public administration. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Public interest is the constitutionally permissible, evidence-based welfare of the community, including persons who are weak, unpopular or not yet able to speak for themselves. Majoritarian preference is what a numerical or politically influential group currently wants. The two may overlap, but they are not identical. A city majority may oppose a night shelter near its homes; an administrator must assess safety, alternative sites, the homeless persons' dignity and equal access, not merely count objections. Public interest therefore requires lawful authority, relevant evidence, proportionality, hearing affected groups and recorded reasons. It rejects both elite paternalism and vote-seeking populism. The proper civil-service role is to convert competing claims into a transparent, reviewable decision anchored in equality, public purpose and long-term trust.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: Differentiate legality, morality and propriety in public office with an example. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Legality asks whether an act is authorised by law or rule. Morality asks whether it respects duties, dignity, fairness and public purpose. Propriety asks whether conduct, including its reasonable appearance, sustains confidence appropriate to public office. They overlap but are not interchangeable. A technically permissible meeting with a bidder may be improper where it creates a credible appearance of preferential access; a lawful choice among relief priorities still needs moral justification through need and equality. Conversely, moral concern cannot create power contrary to law. An officer should first identify the legal floor, then test constitutional values, conflict risk, transparency and foreseeable institutional effects. Disclosure, written reasons and independent scrutiny convert this three-part inquiry into accountable administration. This sequencing also prevents private moral preference from becoming arbitrary public power.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Political neutrality does not require value-neutral administration. Discuss. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Political neutrality means that the permanent executive gives frank professional advice and implements the elected government's lawful decisions without partisan favour, campaign conduct or selective service delivery. It does not mean value-neutrality. Civil servants are constitutionally bound to equality, dignity, rule of law and public interest; they must identify discrimination, procedural unfairness and illegality even when politically inconvenient.

A secretary should place evidence and legal limits before a minister, record material advice and suggest lawful alternatives. Once a revised direction is lawful, neutral implementation requires the same eligibility and service standards for supporters and opponents. In disaster relief, neutrality forbids directing resources to an electoral constituency, while constitutional values require special attention to persons with disability or remote communities facing unequal barriers.

The opposite errors are bureaucratic obstruction of a democratic mandate and obedient participation in unlawful patronage. A sound relationship distinguishes policy choice, for which the political executive is answerable, from competent impartial implementation and evidence-based advice, for which the civil servant is answerable. Fixed procedures, written directions, transfer safeguards and review support that balance. Political neutrality is thus principled constitutional fidelity, not ethical silence.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Conflict-of-interest policy should prevent both concealment and paralysing recusal. Examine. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

A conflict of interest is a risk that private interest will compromise, or reasonably appear to compromise, public duty. A useful policy separates actual, potential and apparent conflicts. An actual conflict, such as evaluating a sibling's tender, generally requires declaration, recusal and reassignment. A potential conflict, such as shares in a sector an officer may later regulate, requires prospective disclosure and a register. An apparent conflict requires transparent reasons and a confidence assessment; it does not automatically establish misconduct.

This distinction prevents two failures. Concealment allows private financial, family or post-employment interests to distort judgment. Blanket recusal, however, can deprive administration of expertise and encourage tactical allegations. The response should be proportionate to materiality, proximity, decision sensitivity and a reasonable informed observer's view.

Institutions need updated declarations, screening before sensitive files, documented decisions, independent ethics advice, cooling-off where justified and audit trails. Disclosure alone is not a cure: the institution must decide whether recusal, conditions or reassignment are required. The goal is neither distrust of every relationship nor tolerance of hidden influence, but defensible decisions that preserve impartiality and public confidence.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: A minister lawfully seeks faster approval for a project, but the request would displace applicants under published eligibility criteria. Analyse the civil servant's ethical response. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

The officer faces a claimed development objective and ministerial expectation on one side, and impartiality, equality, procedural fairness and public trust on the other. Stakeholders include queued applicants, potential beneficiaries, departmental staff, the minister, future applicants and citizens who depend on predictable administration. The officer must first establish whether any proposed acceleration violates law, published criteria, delegated authority or a court direction. An illegal option should be declined through recorded advice, not balanced as if it were merely another ethical preference.

Feasible lawful options include maintaining the queue; creating a general expedited channel under published urgent criteria available to all similarly placed projects; seeking competent approval for a transparent policy revision; or silently prioritising the minister's preferred project. The final option is ethically weakest because it converts status into privilege and creates an appearance of impropriety. A general, evidence-based urgency route may be defensible if it protects comparable claims and records reasons.

The officer should give frank written advice, propose lawful alternatives, disclose any personal connection, preserve the file record and communicate criteria to affected applicants. Affected persons should receive an intelligible opportunity to challenge a material departure. If a lawful final decision is made after advice, it should be implemented neutrally. Accountability requires auditability and an appeal route; leadership requires resisting informal pressure without public grandstanding. The conclusion is principled facilitation: accelerate public purpose through transparent rules, never through selective exception.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: Design an ethically accountable grievance-redress system for a digitally administered welfare programme. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

A grievance system should treat a complaint as both service information and a citizen's claim to fair hearing. It must begin with accessible multi-channel entry: online, assisted offline, telephone and local facilitation, with disability and language support. Each complaint should receive acknowledgement, a tracking number, time standard, responsible officer and protection against retaliation. Data should identify recurring exclusion without exposing complainants unnecessarily.

At decision stage, the officer should verify facts, hear the claimant where adverse action is possible, apply published eligibility criteria, give a speaking reason and provide correction, compensation or referral where warranted. Automated rejection must have a prompt human-review route; technology can reduce arbitrary discretion but cannot transfer accountability to an algorithm. Escalation, independent appeal, conflict screening and audit logs protect impartiality.

The June 2026 DARPG CPGRAMS report can illustrate monitoring: it reports high disposal and pendency indicators. Those metrics are useful for timeliness and managerial review, but they do not establish that every disposal was correct, fair, satisfactory or free from misconduct. The dashboard should therefore report quality sampling, reversal on appeal, repeat grievances, accessibility outcomes and action on systemic causes alongside volume and time.

Nolan openness, honesty and accountability require public standards, anonymised performance disclosure and documented correction. Senior leaders should review patterns rather than reward closure alone, and publish action on persistent causes promptly. The system thereby joins efficiency with dignity, remedy, equality and answerability.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Subject: Ethics | **Tier:** Advanced | **GS Paper:** GS-IV. **Core area:** Deeper treatment of public-service values, the Nolan principles, and structured resolution of hard/multi-duty ethical dilemmas. **Grounded in:** 2nd ARC 4th Report *Ethics in Governance* (2007), Ch.2 (paras 2.2.5-2.6.12); audited GS-IV PYQs (2024-2025 Mains). **FACT:** = source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = inference/analysis | **CURRENT:** = current anchor. *Companion:* basic/09_Public-Service-Values-Status-and-Ethical-Dilemmas.md.

1. Architecture

NOLAN PRINCIPLES (aspirational floor)
Selflessness, Integrity, Objectivity,
Accountability, Openness, Honesty,
Leadership

|
v
CODE OF ETHICS
(broad, aspirational)

|
v
CODE OF CONDUCT
(precise; enforceable where adopted in the applicable framework)

DILEMMA TYPES (where principles collide)

Type 1: Duty vs Duty
(loyalty to superior vs public interest)
Type 2: Value vs Value
(compassion vs impartiality)
Type 3: Individual vs Institutional
(personal conscience vs organisational decision)
Type 4: Short-term vs Long-term
(immediate relief vs sustainable/systemic solution)

Analytical claim: The Nolan principles function as an aspirational *ceiling* while the Code of Conduct functions as an enforceable *floor* - genuine ethical dilemmas live in the gap between them, where conduct is technically lawful but the Nolan-standard resolution is contested.

2. Concepts and distinctions

Concept	Precise meaning
FACT: Selflessness vs self-interest bias (Nolan Principle 1)	Requires decisions "solely in terms of public interest" - the most demanding principle because self-interest can be subtle (reputational, career, ideological) not just financial.
FACT: Objectivity in Nolan's specific sense	Confined to public appointments, contracts, and awarding of benefits - narrower than a general "be unbiased" injunction; it is procedural (merit-based selection), not a claim about value-neutrality in policy itself.
ANALYSIS: Nested dilemmas	Complex administrative situations often contain more than one dilemma simultaneously (e.g., a disaster-relief case combining resource-allocation fairness, personal-versus-duty conflict, and transparency-versus-order-maintenance) - advanced answers should decompose and address each nested dilemma distinctly.
ANALYSIS: Genuine vs manufactured dilemma	A "manufactured" dilemma disguises a simple rule violation as a values conflict (e.g., presenting bribery as "compassionate flexibility") - an advanced skill is distinguishing real value conflicts from rule violations dressed up as dilemmas.
ANALYSIS: Status and role morality	Public office confers authority, informational advantage and control of common resources; the role therefore justifies heightened restraint, impartiality, reasons and scrutiny rather than special personal privilege.
ANALYSIS: Political neutrality	The permanent executive owes lawful implementation to the elected government while retaining duties of frank advice, constitutional fidelity, non-partisanship and recorded professional dissent.
ANALYSIS: Public/private boundary	Family, financial, associational and post-employment relationships become ethically relevant when they intersect with official power; proportionate disclosure, screening, recusal or documentation protects public confidence.
ANALYSIS: Bounded discretion	Administrative judgment is legitimate only within authority, relevant facts, equal criteria, proportionality, written reasons and review; discretion without those safeguards becomes arbitrariness.

3. Detailed treatment

The seven Nolan principles - precise, non-overlapping readings

- FACT: **Selflessness**: decisions "solely" in public interest, not "primarily" - the ARC's citation (2.2.5) uses the strong term, useful for identifying even partial self-interest as a violation.
- FACT: **Integrity**: freedom from financial/other obligation that "might influence" official duty - note this is a *risk-based* standard (potential influence), not requiring proof of actual bias, which is why disclosure/recusal regimes exist even absent demonstrated wrongdoing.
- FACT: **Accountability**: "must submit... to whatever scrutiny is appropriate to their office" - an

explicitly submission-based, externally-facing standard, distinguishing it from mere internal self-assessment (see 11 for accountability vs responsibility).

- FACT: **Openness**: "as open as possible," restricting information "only when the wider public interest clearly demands" - this reverses the default; secrecy requires justification, not disclosure (directly underpinning RTI's presumption of disclosure, see 15).

- FACT: **Honesty**: specifically about *declaring private interests* and resolving resulting conflicts to protect public interest - narrower than a general truthfulness norm; it targets conflict-of-interest management specifically.

- FACT: **Leadership**: promoting the principles "by leadership and example" - makes senior officials responsible not just for their own conduct but for modelling standards that shape subordinates' and institutional culture.

Distinguishing genuine dilemmas from manufactured ones

- ANALYSIS: A genuine dilemma survives even after removing all self-interest and rule-violation from the scenario - e.g., choosing between two lawful, legitimate but competing policy priorities (economic development vs environmental protection in a specific project) is a genuine dilemma.

- ANALYSIS: A manufactured dilemma dissolves once self-interest or rule-violation is named plainly - e.g., "should I accept this gift from a contractor to maintain a good working relationship" is not a genuine dilemma; it is a conflict-of-interest violation framed euphemistically as one.

- ANALYSIS: GS-IV case studies (see 22) deliberately blend both types; a strong answer explicitly tests and states which type it is facing before proceeding to resolution.

Nested dilemmas in complex cases

- ANALYSIS: The 2025 GS-IV DC-Vijay case study nests at least three distinct dilemmas: (1) personal grief vs public duty (an emotional-intelligence dilemma, see 05), (2) resource-allocation fairness in disaster relief (a distributive-justice dilemma, see 08's Rawls/utilitarian tension), and (3) transparency vs maintaining public calm during the crisis (an openness-Nolan-principle dilemma) - advanced answers decompose and resolve each nested layer rather than treating the case as a single monolithic problem.

4. Institutional and reform architecture

- FACT: ARC 2.2.6's Code of Ethics/Code of Conduct distinction operationalises the Nolan principles: the Code of Ethics states the aspirational Nolan-type standard; the Code of Conduct translates narrower, objectively verifiable elements into precise standards. Those standards are sanctionable only where the applicable law or service framework supplies enforcement (see 16).

- ANALYSIS: 2025 GS-IV Q5(a) itself presents a premise contrasting an operating Code of Conduct with a Code of Ethics "not yet put in place" and asks for a suitable model. Use that as the question's framing; do not generalise it into a live status claim for every category of Indian public office without separate official verification.

5. Indian applications and boundary cases

- ANALYSIS: A civil servant recusing themselves from a tender evaluation involving a relative's firm operationalises Nolan's integrity principle even absent any proven wrongdoing - the risk-based standard justifies precautionary recusal.

- ANALYSIS: Boundary case: an official disclosing sensitive but non-security-critical information under RTI despite departmental reluctance operationalises Nolan's openness principle (secrecy requires justification) - but must still respect legitimate exemptions (security, ongoing investigation) under law (see 15).

6. Limitations and trade-offs

- ANALYSIS: The Nolan principles, being aspirational, carry no direct sanction; without a linked Code of Conduct they risk becoming what the ARC (2.4.3) itself calls "not comprehensive... a list of prohibitions" if left unaccompanied by ethics guidance, or purely rhetorical if left unaccompanied by enforceable rules.
- ANALYSIS: Distinguishing genuine from manufactured dilemmas requires judgment that can itself be biased - officials under real pressure may sincerely (but wrongly) perceive a rule violation as a legitimate values conflict, a risk that institutional checks (peer review, vigilance oversight) must guard against.

7. Must-Know Facts for Advanced Prelims

- FACT: The Nolan Committee's formal name is the UK Committee on Standards in Public Life (established 1994, seven principles issued 1995).
- FACT: ARC's own recommendation (2.4.5) was that a Code of Ethics be created *in addition to* the existing Code of Conduct for Ministers, monitored by dedicated units in the PM's/CM's offices with an annual report to the legislature.
- FACT: 2025 GS-IV Q5(a) explicitly frames its own problem as a Code of Conduct "already in operation" and a Code of Ethics "not yet put in place." Attribute this to the paper's premise rather than treating it as proof of status across all public-office categories.
- FACT: ARC 2.4.5(b)-(d) also specify *how* such a Code should be monitored: dedicated units in the offices of the Prime Minister and Chief Ministers, empowered to receive public complaints, with an annual report on observance - including specific violations and action taken - submitted to the appropriate legislature, and all three documents (Code of Ethics, Code of Conduct, annual report) placed in the public domain.

8. Advanced Prelims traps

- WRONG: Nolan's "objectivity" principle requires value-neutral policymaking generally. -> It is specifically about merit-based decisions in appointments, contracts and benefits - a narrower, procedural standard.
- WRONG: A genuine ethical dilemma always involves two "equally good" options. -> Options can be legitimately unequal in ethical weight; the dilemma is that both options honour some legitimate, competing duty, not that they are equivalent in merit.
- WRONG: The 2025 paper proves that no Indian public body has any Code of Ethics. -> The paper supplies a problem premise for the answer; implementation status varies by institution and must be independently verified before making a general claim.
- WRONG: The Nolan wording the ARC reproduces is the current UK text. -> The ARC quotes the Committee on Standards in Public Life's **1995** formulation; the UK's official wording has since been revised. Cite the ARC's version as the ARC's, not as today's UK standard.

9. CURRENT: Current-anchor application

Verified current anchor	Topic-specific analytical use
CURRENT: DARPG, <i>CPGRAMS Monthly Report for Central Ministries/Departments, June 2026</i>	The report states that June 2026 was the 48th consecutive month with Central Secretariat disposal above one lakh, with 78,793 pending grievances, about 68% pending under 21 days, and 83,544 new registrations. ANALYSIS: These metrics illustrate answerability and administrative monitoring; ethical accountability additionally requires fair reasons, remedy quality, accessibility and non-retaliation.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- FACT: 2025 GS-IV Q5(a) rewards a candidate who (a) states the Code of Ethics/Code of Conduct distinction precisely, (b) works within the implementation premise given by the question, and (c) proposes a specific Nolan-principle-based model with monitoring and reporting safeguards.
- FACT: 2025 GS-IV Q7 (Section B case study) rewards decomposition into nested dilemmas (personal/duty, distributive-justice, transparency) rather than a single blended narrative response.

11. Mains-ready framework

Central thesis: Ethical dilemmas in Indian public service occupy the gap between an aspirational Nolan-type Code of Ethics and an enforceable Code of Conduct; resolving them requires first testing whether the dilemma is genuine or manufactured, then decomposing any nested sub-dilemmas, and finally checking the proposed resolution against all seven Nolan principles for public defensibility.

1. State the dilemma(s) precisely; test genuine vs manufactured.
2. Identify how public status, role morality, political neutrality or a private relationship shapes the duty.
3. Decompose nested dilemmas if more than one competing-duty pair exists.
4. Apply the relevant Nolan principle(s), constitutional boundary and bounded-discretion tests.
5. Apply a moral-theory triangulation (08) to each sub-dilemma.
6. Give a recorded, reviewable resolution defensible under external scrutiny.

12. Probable questions

- ANALYSIS: **Prelims:** Which of the seven Nolan principles specifically addresses declaration of private interests?
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (10 marks):** Distinguish a genuine ethical dilemma from a rule violation disguised as one, with an Indian administrative example.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (15 marks):** Suggest a suitable model Code of Ethics for Indian public administration, grounded in the Nolan principles and the ARC's 2007 recommendation.

13. Study links

- FACT: Foundation companion:
basic/09_Public-Service-Values-Status-and-Ethical-Dilemmas.md.
- FACT: 16_Codes-of-Ethics-and-Codes-of-Conduct.md - full statutory/institutional detail.
- FACT: 11_Accountability-and-Ethical-Governance.md - accountability principle in institutional depth.
- FACT: 22_Case-Study-Method-and-Answer-Architecture.md - nested-dilemma decomposition in practice.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS3-GS4-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023
- **Paper(s):** GS-IV
- **Routed question demands:** 15

Semantic table split - Year

- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 2

- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) meaning of public interest and principles for civil servants; (b) RTI redefining the concept of accountability
- **Directive / format:** Explain/Discuss · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 3
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) conflict of interest - actual vs potential with examples; (b) Warren Buffett quote on integrity intelligence and energy for hiring
- **Directive / format:** Illustrate/Explain · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 5
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) government dam construction in forest valley inhabited by ethnic communities - rational policy for unforeseen contingencies; (b) process of resolving ethical dilemmas in public administration
- **Directive / format:** Suggest/Explain · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Rakesh (district officer) - elderly couple applies for senior citizen healthcare scheme; surgeon willing to operate free but couple cannot afford incidental costs; how should he respond
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** SP appointed in prohibition state notorious for illicit liquor distillation causing deaths; what new approach to bring problem under control
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 1

- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) basic principles of public life with examples; (b) meaning of public servant and expected role
- **Directive / format:** Discuss · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Woman SP appointed in frontier narcotics district - money laundering poppy farming arms smuggling education collapse; identify dimensions and suggest measures to restore normalcy
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** DC of tribal Rampura district: minor girls trafficked to cotton farms as child labour by contractors; identify ethical issues; steps to ameliorate conditions and economic scenario
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** migrant workers during COVID lockdown: ethical issues in crisis; meaning of ethical care and ethical giving; civil society role in mitigating migrant suffering
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 2
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) digital technology as reliable input for rational decision making - critically evaluate; (b) innovativeness and creativity in resolving ethical dilemmas
- **Directive / format:** Critically evaluate / Discuss · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8

- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Vice Principal faces management pressure to suppress exam cheating involving students of influential local politician and businessman - (a) ethical issues; (b) options and best course
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** COVID-19 hospital administrator: criteria and justification for deploying clinical and non-clinical staff in infectious crisis; whether justification differs for a private hospital
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2022
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 1
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) wisdom in administration and travesty of justice in service delivery; (b) empathy and compassion as vital attributes for civil servants
- **Directive / format:** Critically evaluate (a); Explain (b) · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 2
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** (a) corruption as failure of core values and measures to uplift society; (b) coercion vs undue influence in work environment
- **Directive / format:** Discuss (a); Differentiate (b) · 10 + 10 marks · 150 words each
- **Source status:** Routed to owning Ethics topic
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on District Magistrate (AIIMS physician) facing blood-transfusion dilemma during a landslide relief operation
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.

What this owner must now support

- (a) meaning of public interest and principles for civil servants; (b) RTI redefining the concept of accountability
- (a) conflict of interest - actual vs potential with examples; (b) Warren Buffett quote on integrity intelligence and energy for hiring

- (a) government dam construction in forest valley inhabited by ethnic communities - rational policy for unforeseen contingencies; (b) process of resolving ethical dilemmas in public administration
- Rakesh (district officer) - elderly couple applies for senior citizen healthcare scheme; surgeon willing to operate free but couple cannot afford incidental costs; how should he respond
- SP appointed in prohibition state notorious for illicit liquor distillation causing deaths; what new approach to bring problem under control
- (a) basic principles of public life with examples; (b) meaning of public servant and expected role
- Woman SP appointed in frontier narcotics district - money laundering poppy farming arms smuggling education collapse; identify dimensions and suggest measures to restore normalcy
- DC of tribal Rampura district: minor girls trafficked to cotton farms as child labour by contractors; identify ethical issues; steps to ameliorate conditions and economic scenario
- migrant workers during COVID lockdown: ethical issues in crisis; meaning of ethical care and ethical giving; civil society role in mitigating migrant suffering
- (a) digital technology as reliable input for rational decision making - critically evaluate; (b) innovativeness and creativity in resolving ethical dilemmas
- Vice Principal faces management pressure to suppress exam cheating involving students of influential local politician and businessman - (a) ethical issues; (b) options and best course
- COVID-19 hospital administrator: criteria and justification for deploying clinical and non-clinical staff in infectious crisis; whether justification differs for a private hospital
- (a) wisdom in administration and travesty of justice in service delivery; (b) empathy and compassion as vital attributes for civil servants
- (a) corruption as failure of core values and measures to uplift society; (b) coercion vs undue influence in work environment
- Case on District Magistrate (AIIMS physician) facing blood-transfusion dilemma during a landslide relief operation

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

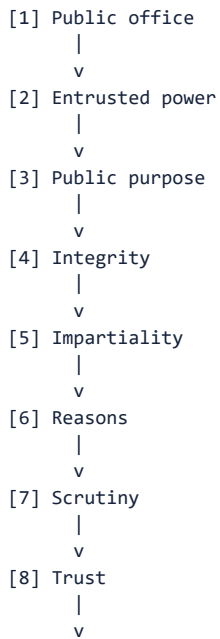
EMBEDDED TWELVE-PANEL ASCII REVISION ATLAS

The panels compress the learning route without replacing the complete teaching and solved practice above.

ASCII PANEL 1/12 - 1. Public trust chain

CENTRAL FOCUS

1. Public trust chain



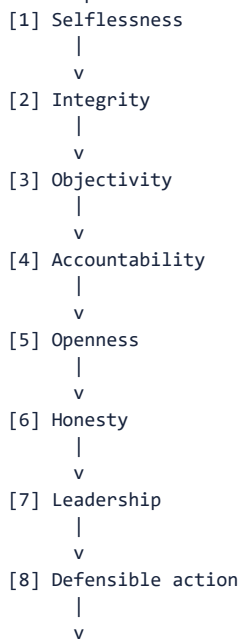
VERDICT -> Status heightens restraint and answerability.

ANSWER USE -> Open a public-service-values answer.

ASCII PANEL 2/12 - 2. Nolan public-life rail

CENTRAL FOCUS

2. Nolan public-life rail



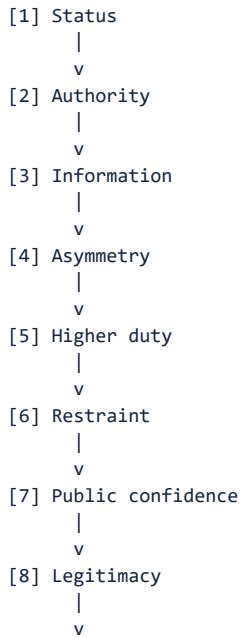
VERDICT -> Use Nolan as an ARC-cited checklist, not an India-specific code.

ANSWER USE -> Use in values and Code-of-Ethics answers.

ASCII PANEL 3/12 - 3. Status and role morality

CENTRAL FOCUS

3. Status and role morality



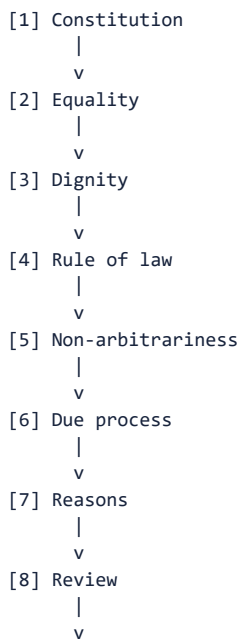
VERDICT -> Role duty serves constitutional public purpose.

ANSWER USE -> Use for 2019 public-servant demand.

ASCII PANEL 4/12 - 4. Constitutional decision boundary

CENTRAL FOCUS

4. Constitutional decision boundary



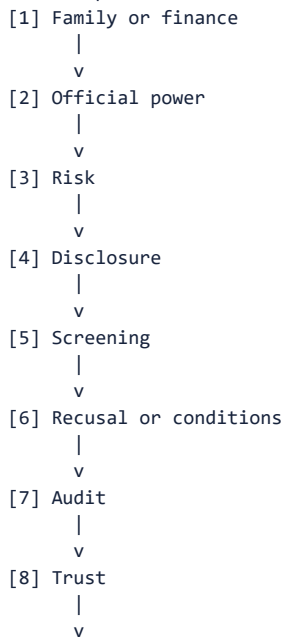
VERDICT -> Neutrality never excuses constitutional indifference.

ANSWER USE -> Use for political-executive directions.

ASCII PANEL 5/12 - 5. Public-private interface

CENTRAL FOCUS

5. Public-private interface



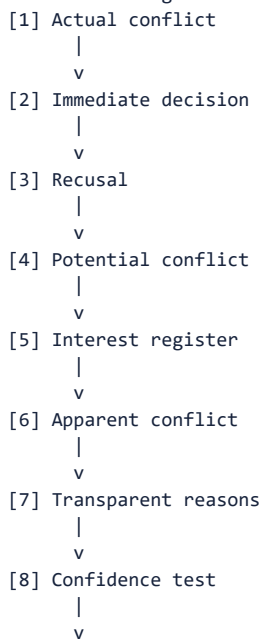
VERDICT -> Private interest must be managed before it distorts public duty.

ANSWER USE -> Use for conflict-of-interest questions.

ASCII PANEL 6/12 - 6. Conflict management ladder

CENTRAL FOCUS

6. Conflict management ladder



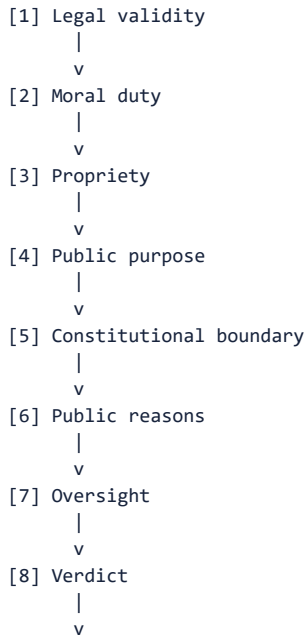
VERDICT -> Scale safeguards to materiality; disclosure alone is not resolution.

ANSWER USE -> Use for 2018 Q3(a).

ASCII PANEL 7/12 - 7. Legality, morality and propriety

CENTRAL FOCUS

7. Legality, morality and propriety



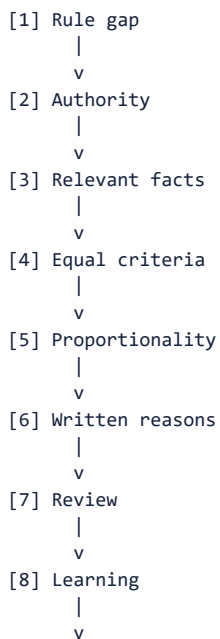
VERDICT -> Legal permission is necessary but may not complete ethical justification.

ANSWER USE -> Use in law-versus-ethics answers.

ASCII PANEL 8/12 - 8. Bounded discretion

CENTRAL FOCUS

8. Bounded discretion



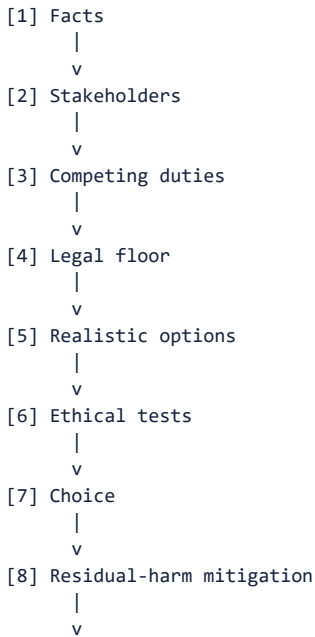
VERDICT -> Discretion is reviewable judgment, not personal freedom.

ANSWER USE -> Use for emergency and service-delivery cases.

ASCII PANEL 9/12 - 9. Dilemma resolution sequence

CENTRAL FOCUS

9. Dilemma resolution sequence



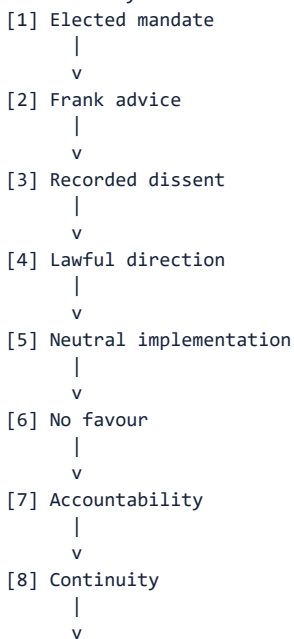
VERDICT -> Name genuine conflict before choosing a proportionate response.

ANSWER USE -> Use for 2018 Q5(b) and cases.

ASCII PANEL 10/12 - 10. Neutrality and elected mandate

CENTRAL FOCUS

10. Neutrality and elected mandate



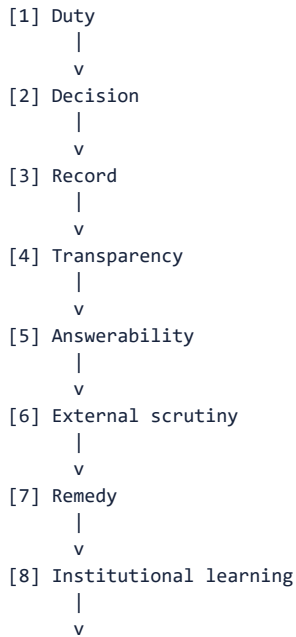
VERDICT -> Advise frankly; implement lawful decisions without partisanship.

ANSWER USE -> Use for political neutrality.

ASCII PANEL 11/12 - 11. Accountability loop

CENTRAL FOCUS

11. Accountability loop



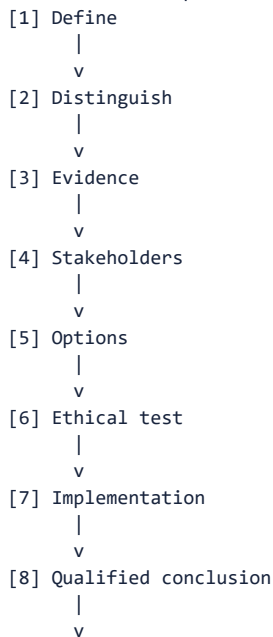
VERDICT -> Responsibility becomes accountability through scrutiny and correction.

ANSWER USE -> Use with CPGRAMS and grievance cases.

ASCII PANEL 12/12 - 12. Mains answer spine

CENTRAL FOCUS

12. Mains answer spine



VERDICT -> A reasoned, reviewable verdict outperforms a moral slogan.

ANSWER USE -> Use in every Topic 09 Mains response.

ONE-PAGE CONCEPT GRID

Concept / thinker	Exam-ready formulation
Public office is a public trust	Public office confers entrusted authority, information and discretion for public purpose; status therefore increases rather than relaxes the duty of restraint, reason-giving and conduct that can retain citizens' confidence.
Role morality is bounded by constitutional public purpose	Role morality gives an official special duties of fidelity, competence and impartial implementation, but it cannot licence discrimination, concealment or personal loyalty where these defeat constitutional values, lawful authority or public interest.
Public interest is not majoritarian preference	Public interest concerns constitutionally permissible, evidence-based welfare of the community, including affected minorities and future citizens; it is not identical to electoral popularity, a minister's preference or the loudest group's immediate demand.
Status creates an appearance obligation	Because public authority depends on confidence, officials should avoid impropriety and its reasonable appearance; this is not a demand for private perfection but a duty to manage relationships and conduct that could credibly compromise official judgment.
Integrity excludes compromising obligations	Nolan integrity requires public office holders not to place themselves under financial or other obligations that might influence official duty; risk of compromised judgment matters before proof of actual bias or corrupt payment.
Objectivity is merit-based official procedure	Nolan objectivity requires appointments, contracts and benefits to be decided on merit and stated criteria; it is a procedural guard against favouritism, not a claim that public policy can be wholly value-neutral.
Impartiality and political neutrality differ	Impartiality applies relevant criteria equally among persons; political neutrality requires non-partisan advice and implementation under the elected government. Neither requires indifference to constitutional rights, evidence or unlawful directions.
Accountability is answerability to scrutiny	Accountability requires an office holder to explain and justify decisions to appropriate external scrutiny and accept consequences or correction; it exceeds private sincerity and differs from merely having responsibility to perform an assigned task.
A genuine dilemma conflicts legitimate duties	An ethical dilemma arises when two legitimate duties, values or loyalties cannot both be fully honoured; it differs from a simple temptation to obtain gain by breaking a known rule or disguising favouritism as compassion.
Legality is a floor, not the whole ethical inquiry	A legal prohibition removes an option from ordinary ethical choice, but technical legality does not automatically establish morality or propriety; officials must also test public purpose, equality, constitutional values, reasons and foreseeable institutional effects.
Stakeholder mapping prevents tunnel vision	Dilemma resolution begins by identifying affected citizens, weaker groups, colleagues, institutions and future interests; mapping them exposes hidden burdens before an official chooses among lawful alternatives or invokes a public-good slogan.

Concept / thinker	Exam-ready formulation
A defensible resolution is reasoned and reviewable	After excluding unlawful options, an official should compare realistic alternatives through duties, consequences and virtues, select a proportionate option, record reasons, communicate it fairly and mitigate residual harm under independent or administrative review.

CORE REVISION SPINE

- **Actual conflict calls for recusal:** An actual conflict exists when a private interest and an immediate official decision directly collide; the normal safeguard is prompt declaration, removal from the particular decision and reassignment, rather than waiting to prove corrupt motive or outcome.
- **Potential conflict is managed prospectively:** A potential conflict is a private interest that could later intersect with official duty; proactive disclosure and a register enable later screening, while automatic present recusal is unnecessary where no relevant decision is before the officer.
- **Apparent conflict requires confidence protection:** An apparent conflict exists where a reasonable informed observer could suspect compromised judgment despite no proved private benefit; transparency, reasons and sometimes voluntary recusal preserve confidence without mechanically treating appearance as established corruption.
- **Disclosure does not itself resolve conflict:** Declaration is a necessary first safeguard but does not cleanse every conflict; the institution must assess materiality, decide recusal, reassignment or conditions, record the response and ensure the private interest cannot distort public decision-making.
- **Coercion overbears choice through threat:** Coercion compels conduct through an explicit or implicit threat of harm, such as punitive transfer, dismissal or retaliation; apparent consent under such duress is not a reliable ethical defence for the pressured official or decision.
- **Undue influence exploits dependency without threat:** Undue influence exploits trust, authority or dependency to bend another's autonomous judgment without an overt threat; it requires attention to relationship patterns, career vulnerability and informal pressure rather than only searching for a provable quid pro quo.
- **Discretion needs legal purpose and recorded reasons:** Discretion is not personal freedom: it must stay within authority, pursue statutory and constitutional purpose, use relevant facts and equal criteria, remain proportionate and be documented so that citizens, supervisors and courts can review it.
- **Automation can reduce but not erase accountability:** Automating rule-bound services can reduce arbitrary discretion and improve traceability, but accountable administration still requires accessible alternatives, human review of exclusion, reliable data and responsibility for biased design, implementation and redress.
- **Openness has a justified public-interest limit:** Nolan openness favours maximum disclosure, but information may be restricted when a clear wider public-interest and lawful ground supports it; secrecy must be justified, narrowly tailored and not used to conceal embarrassment, favouritism or maladministration.
- **Honesty includes private-interest declaration:** In the Nolan formulation, honesty specifically requires declaration of private interests relating to public duties and resolution of resulting conflicts; ordinary truthfulness remains important, but this principle directly targets transparent conflict management.
- **Leadership shapes institutional ethical climate:** Nolan leadership requires senior office holders to promote public-life values through personal example, fair systems and response to misconduct; ethical culture cannot be created by slogans while leaders reward target achievement obtained through improper means.
- **Metrics illustrate monitoring, not complete ethics:** Disposal, pendency and response-time metrics can make administrative monitoring visible, but they do not by themselves prove correctness, fairness, satisfaction, impartiality or absence of misconduct; qualitative review and remedy remain necessary.

SOURCE AND ATTRIBUTION DISCIPLINE

The Topic 09 Basic and Advanced owners are controlling sources for public-service values, Nolan principles, conflict-of-interest taxonomy, coercion/undue influence and dilemma diagnosis. Topic 09 interfaces with but must not duplicate Topic 10 (laws, rules and conscience), Topic 11 (accountability), Topic 14 (probity), Topic 16 (Codes of Ethics/Conduct) and Topic 22 (complete case-study architecture). The Nolan wording cited by ARC is the 1995 UK formulation, not a claim about the current UK wording. A Code of Conduct should not be called sanctionable solely on ARC 2.2.6 wording. A genuine dilemma is not every unethical act; do not describe GS-IV cases as almost entirely genuine dilemmas. Treat the 2024 Code-of-Ethics statement as a PYQ premise, not a universal current-status finding. Constitutional morality is primarily cross-owned; 2025 Q1(b) must not be claimed as a direct Topic 09 route. Historical ledger labels may be neutral renderings: quote official wording only where verified against the stated local GS-IV PDF.

ANSWER SPINE

1. Define the precise ethical concept or teaching.
2. State a qualified thesis rather than a moral slogan.
3. Explain the causal or decision-making mechanism.
4. Add one specific Indian administrative illustration.
5. Test the strongest limitation or attribution caveat.
6. End with a practical, institution-aware verdict.

PUBLIC OFFICE - power, status and information are held in trust; role morality requires faithful, competent, impartial service but cannot override constitutional equality, dignity or legality. NOLAN/ARC - selflessness; integrity; objectivity; accountability; openness; honesty; leadership. Integrity manages compromising obligations; objectivity is merit procedure; honesty includes interest declaration; accountability is answerability to scrutiny. PUBLIC/PRIVATE - actual conflict: declare, recuse, reassign; potential: disclose/register/screen; apparent: transparent reasons and confidence test. Disclosure alone does not cure a material conflict. NORMS - legality is a floor; morality tests duty and fairness; propriety protects public confidence beyond criminal liability. DISCRETION - authority, relevant facts, equal criteria, proportionality, reasons, review. DILEMMA - facts -> stakeholders -> competing legitimate duties -> legal floor -> options -> duty/consequence/virtue tests -> proportionate choice -> implementation and residual-risk mitigation. POWER - coercion uses threat; undue influence exploits dependency without overt threat. NEUTRALITY - give frank non-partisan advice; record material dissent; implement lawful final decisions without favour or fear. METRICS - CPGRAMS data illustrate monitoring, never by themselves fairness, correctness, satisfaction or integrity. ANSWER SPINE - define precisely, distinguish close concepts, use one verified example, state safeguards and conclude with a reviewable constitutional-public-interest verdict.